

Archangel

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Prologue

It was a cold evening, the kind of cold that slipped through layers of clothing and settled deep in the bones. A steady wind swept across the city rooftops, carrying the metallic scent of rain and the distant hum of traffic below. The sky hung low beneath a blanket of heavy clouds, swallowing the last traces of daylight and hinting at the fast-approaching winter. I knelt on the roof of a warehouse, tucked behind the bulky frame of a generator. Its constant mechanical rumble vibrated through the concrete beneath me, offering a thin veil of noise to mask my presence. The metal casing was cold against my shoulder, even through my armor and I could feel the dampness of the evening air gathering on every exposed surface.

From my position, I had a narrow view over the edge of the roof and across the maze of industrial buildings beyond. Their windows glowed faintly in the growing darkness, scattered islands of pale yellow and sterile white among endless stretches of steel and concrete. Exhaust vents coughed steam into the cold air. Cargo drones drifted silently between distant towers, their navigation lights blinking like wandering stars.

Somewhere in the city, a bell tolled mournfully, its deep notes carrying farther than they should have through the night. One. Two. Three.

Almost midnight. Another hour was added to the mental clock that never stopped running in the back of my mind.

Five years, two weeks, three days, seven hours, and forty minutes.

That's how long it had been since my brothers vanished.

No bodies.

No answers.

No final message, no ransom demand, no trace worth a damn.

Just a clock that never stopped counting, and me filling the empty space between its ticks with things I never thought I'd do.

Smuggling. Theft. Corporate espionage. A few jobs that sat in the gray area between legal and criminal, where the rules were flexible and the consequences weren't.

The kind of work that paid well enough to keep searching. The kind of work that slowly changed a person.

I pushed the thoughts aside and slowed my breathing until even my enhanced hearing barely registered it.

The city faded into the background—distant engines, humming power lines, the rhythmic clatter of machinery several blocks away.

My pulse settled. Muscles loosened. One tap against the control port on my hip. The blue-green glow of my cybernetics vanished instantly. Darkness swallowed me. The augmented overlay that usually painted the world in thermal signatures, threat markers, and targeting data winked out, leaving only shadows and moonlight. For a brief moment I felt naked without it, stripped of the artificial senses I'd relied on for years.

Blind and exposed to the night. Just the way I needed to be.

Across the street, the target building stood silent. Security patrols followed their predictable routes. Cameras swept through their programmed arcs.

Behind reinforced walls sat a prize worth more credits than I'd earn in a decade of honest work.

One more job.

Get in.

Get out.

Pay off the last chunk of debt from the Ghost-Class armor I'd upgraded to. A couple steps below Wraith-Class, but still capable of stopping a rail round and outrunning a turret's targeting solution.

Expensive as hell. Worth every credit.

Pain hurts more than guilt ever did.

My fingers brushed the armored plating beneath my jacket. I could still remember signing the loan agreement. Remember the interest rates. Remember realizing I'd just sold years of my life for a chance to survive a little longer.

But survival had a way of becoming addictive.

Almost free. The thought lingered in the darkness.

Almost.

Gravel shifted below me. I froze. Every muscle locked in place. Even the wind seemed to vanish.

For a heartbeat, the only sound was the low growl of the generator at my back and the distant pulse of the city beyond the warehouse district.

Another tap. Emerald vision flared to life. The darkness shattered. Heat signatures bled into the world like coals in a furnace, painting every living thing in shades of amber, gold, and white. Night vision layered itself beneath the thermal feed, outlines sharpening as targeting software quietly synchronized the two streams. Distances. Angles. Movement vectors.

Five figures. Two baseline humans. Thin silhouettes wrapped in heavy coats, moving with the nervous energy of people who knew exactly what kind of company they kept.

Their hearts fluttered visibly through the thermal overlay, rapid flashes in their chests like trapped birds beating against a cage.

Three Fomori. The giants stalked between them. Slab-built monsters, broad enough to block an alley and tall enough to make ordinary men look adolescent by comparison.

Their Aegis-Class dermal plating caught the faint ambient light in dull metallic ridges where synthetic armor merged seamlessly with flesh. The thermal feed showed heat pouring from them in waves, each one radiating like an industrial engine.

Fuck their armor.

Aegis-Class wasn't protection. It was a philosophy.

Become the wall. Become the tank.

Let the other bastard run out of ammunition first.

They traded speed, stealth, and comfort for raw survivability. Small-arms fire bounced. Explosives annoyed them. Most people faced with a charging Fomori discovered exactly how fragile the human body really was.

Corporate muscle. The kind companies deployed when they wanted a problem solved publicly. The kind built to break doors and people with equal efficiency.

One of them turned its head, scanning the rooftops. My targeting suite immediately highlighted threat probabilities, escape routes, and estimated engagement outcomes. None of them looked good.

I held perfectly still. My lungs burned as I resisted the urge to breathe.

Don't move. Don't twitch. Don't give the sensors anything to catch.

The group continued down the alley below, boots crunching over loose gravel and discarded debris. The humans talked quietly among themselves. One of the Fomori laughed—a deep metallic rumble that echoed between the warehouse walls.

Seconds stretched. Then they kept walking. Good. Let them pass. Let them disappear into the night. And for once, this job might actually finish clean.

Job was simple enough. Get in the building, grab the goods, and get out.

Experience didn't buy simple.

It never had.

The patrol rounded the corner, boots grinding against the gravel below. Their voices faded into the maze of warehouses and loading yards.

I stayed motionless, counting the seconds in my head.

Five.

Ten.

Fifteen.

The heat signatures dwindled at the edge of my HUD, shrinking to distant embers before vanishing entirely.

Silence reclaimed the rooftop.

I rose from my crouch. My knees protested immediately. Hours spent perched on concrete and steel had left them stiff despite the reinforcement braces woven through my armor.

The city wind swept across the rooftop, tugging at my jacket and slipping through the seams of my gear. It carried the familiar scent of the industrial district—ozone from overloaded transformers, rust from aging metal, and the faint chemical bite of exhaust from the street-level generators.

Then the world lurched sideways.

Frag!

Pain exploded through my skull.

It felt like someone had driven a white-hot spike through my right eye and buried it deep in the center of my brain.

The pain hit so suddenly that my vision went white for a fraction of a second. My balance disappeared with it. My vision fractured.

I staggered. One hand shot out and slammed against the generator housing before I could fall. Cold metal bit into my palm. The world refused to stay still.

My night-vision feed shattered into emerald static. Thousands of bright green pixels danced across my vision like a swarm of insects. Diagnostic windows erupted across my HUD faster than I could process them. Warnings, system checks, error codes. Half of them vanished before I could read them. The other half dissolved into corrupted symbols.

The rooftop flickered.

One moment I was staring at a rusted ventilation duct twenty feet away. The next it was gone. Replaced by darkness. Then the darkness vanished and the rooftop snapped back into existence.

Then darkness again.

Then color.

Then black.

The transitions came so quickly my stomach rolled.

A high-pitched whine began somewhere deep inside my skull. At first I thought it was coming from the generator. Then I thought it was coming from my comms. Then I realized I wasn't hearing it at all. I was feeling it.

The vibration crawled through my teeth and jawbone, rattling the tiny implants buried along the base of my skull.

Every cybernetic component in my body suddenly felt present. The ocular replacements behind my eyes. The neural jack at the base of my neck. The reinforcement mesh threaded through my spine.

I became aware of all of it at once.

Every piece of machinery. Every foreign component. Every gram of metal living inside me. The sensation was nauseating.

My right eye twitched violently. The HUD tried to recalibrate. Failed. Tried again. Failed again.

Thermal imaging flooded my vision without warning. Heat signatures smeared across the rooftop in brilliant oranges and whites.

A heartbeat later the thermal layer vanished and low-light optics took over. Then both systems attempted to run simultaneously.

The result looked like someone had poured molten glass over reality.

I squeezed my eyes shut. That somehow made it worse. The pain intensified instantly. A tremor raced down my neck and into my shoulders. My muscles locked.

For a terrifying moment I couldn't tell if my body was shaking or if the rooftop itself was vibrating beneath me.

My pulse hammered in my ears. Too fast.

Far too fast.

I tasted copper.

Blood.

I had bitten down hard enough to split the inside of my cheek. The metallic taste spread across my tongue.

The whine climbed higher.

Higher.

Higher.

My implants felt hot. Not physically hot. Not enough to burn. Just wrong. Like circuitry operating beyond tolerances. Like a machine trying desperately to do something it wasn't designed to do.

I dropped to one knee. The impact jarred through my armor.

Even that felt distant. Muffled. As though my body belonged to someone else and the pain was arriving through a damaged connection.

"Not now..." I hissed through clenched teeth.

The words sounded strange. Distant. Like I was hearing someone else speak.

My hand tightened against the concrete until the armored glove creaked and the concrete cracked beneath it.

Seconds dragged by. Each one felt hours longer than the last.

Then, as suddenly as it had begun, the pressure eased. The whine faltered. The static thinned. The fractured layers of vision slowly drifted back into alignment.

Diagnostic windows stabilized.

The rooftop stopped spinning. The pain retreated from a screaming inferno to a dull, familiar throb behind my eye.

I stayed where I was, breathing hard, waiting for another wave. It didn't come.

One breath.

Then another. Long enough for the pain to retreat behind my eye and become manageable. Long enough for the rooftop to stop pitching beneath my feet.

Not long enough to trust that the episode was over.

Good enough.

It would have to be.

I stepped to the edge of the roof and jumped.

Air rushed past, cold and electric.

The city rose to meet me in a blur of concrete, steel, and fractured neon. Wind clawed at my jacket and roared in my ears, drowning out the distant hum of traffic and machinery.

For a brief moment, gravity owned me.

Mid-fall, I triggered the reinforcement servos in my legs. A fraction later than I should have. Part of it was habit. Part of it was distraction. Part of it was the lingering question of whether the implants would decide to eat themselves again before I hit the ground.

My HUD apparently shared the concern. A small amber warning appeared in the corner of my vision.

OPTIMAL ENGAGEMENT WINDOW EXCEEDED.

"No shit," I muttered.

The ground rushed up. I hit in a crouch. The shock dampeners ignited through the armor, dumping the impact into the reinforcement frame. Heat flashed through my knees, hips, and lower back as the system dispersed the force.

The landing drove a dull jolt up my spine. Still better than shattered ankles.

I straightened carefully. A faint tremor lingered in my hands.

Whether from the jump or the episode, I couldn't tell. The street was empty.

Silent, save for the distant buzz of neon billboards and the low rhythmic pulse of a rooftop drone somewhere overhead.

Vesper

Everything felt on edge. Breaking in had been too easy the service door's lock barely put up a fight, the security keypad still running factory firmware. No alarms rang out. One soft, click and the door swung inward like it had been expecting me. Never a good sign. Inside, the halls felt wrong — too clean, too empty. Fluorescent strips buzzed overhead, their light thin and clinical as a surgeon's lamp. It bounced off sterile walls and polished concrete that refused to hold a fingerprint. No foot traffic. No drones careening through the vents. Not even a bored rent-a-corp seated in a chair doom scrolling the net. My camera loop ran perfect, a seamless feed of empty corridor after empty corridor. It should've calmed me. It didn't. It made my nerves itch like static under a sock. The air tasted of recycled vent output left running too long: stale and metallic, with a faint chemical tang I couldn't place. I paused and pulled up the intel packet. Schematics flickered in the corner of my vision: access routes, maintenance shafts, redacted sections that made my teeth grind. Target: sub-basement. Floor tag: 7. I'd have to drop five, maybe six floors if the corp architects got cute with extra unlabeled floors. They loved burying secrets deeper than they hid ethics. A low vibration hummed through the floor plating under my boots — heavy machinery somewhere below, cycling in a slow, steady rhythm. It was almost comforting, that mechanical heartbeat. Almost. My reflection ghosted across the HUD for a second: green eyes rimmed in dark, tired lines, a faint crawling static dancing across the overlay. The static felt personal, as if something inside me wanted attention. I scrubbed it away. This should've been a team job: sweep, breach, extraction. Divide the risk, divide the fire. Instead someone had insisted a single Kinzan could slip in clean. Or that a single Kinzan was expendable. Either way, I was solo, and my mouth tasted like iron because of it. I moved fast. The service stairs were concrete, the handrail polished slick with oil and anonymous fingerprints. My boots ate the descent in three even sets of two; the echo of my steps was the loudest sound in the building. Sub-level six opened like an artery: narrow hallways, service doors every few meters, labels that meant nothing and everything. Still empty. The building was breathing around me, and I felt like the only foreign body inside it. I eventually hit the floor I needed to be on. And it was short work reaching the door. I glanced over my shoulder, then set my back to the cold steel door. The lock was reinforced: mag-hold with a tiny diagnostics strip blinking amber. I fed a bypass spike into the access port, felt the relay click under my glove, then a hiccup. The spike met resistance, microscopic pins catching on an unseen latch. I cursed softly and worked the spike. The strip flickered amber, then green. The door clicked open. Relief was thin; it tasted worse than the cheap synth-coffee I'd been living off of. I slipped inside and eased the door shut behind me. The latch clicked soft as breath. The HUD flickered once, then again. Overlay symbols crowding my vision as it tried to tag every surface in sight. Power conduits. Heat signatures. Unknown compounds. A mess of pop-ups, all bright and eager, all noise. "Not now," I muttered, blinking twice to suppress the AR flood. The system hesitated like a sulking dog before dimming to a minimal display. I took a step forward. The air felt heavier here, filtered but stale, with that faint antiseptic bite labs always have, like someone had scrubbed away something worse. It was a lab, all right. Not what I was expecting, but somehow not a surprise either. Long counters lined both walls, cluttered with sealed sample canisters, spent diagnostic cartridges, and shattered glassware that no one

had bothered to sweep up. The lighting was too bright in places, too dark in others, half the strips flickering, half burned out. A row of suspended monitors hung from the ceiling, cycling through frozen data screens. Whatever they'd been working on, the process had been interrupted mid-step. Cooling fans still whined somewhere deep in the room. A faint hum under the floor suggested active systems—life support, containment, something. I moved further in, careful where I placed my boots. My reflection ghosted across a glass panel, warped by some fluid behind it. For a second, the HUD picked up a heat source where there shouldn't have been one. An outline, vaguely human, curled in on itself. Then it vanished. Glitch or not, it made the back of my neck prickle. I shook my head, dismissing the floating overlays until the room went quiet again—just the muted glow of night vision and the slow bloom of heat from the machinery around me. Clean. Controlled. Manageable. Then I brought back the info packet, a thin strip of data scrolling across the corner of my vision. I flicked through encrypted notes and redacted lines until a description popped up—small glass vial, six centimeters long, steel cap, cryo-stamped label reading Project: Archangel. That was all I needed. I set my internal scanners to active search mode. A soft pulse rippled through the space—short-range sweep calibrated for compound density and temperature variation. The HUD painted faint wire-frames over the lab benches, highlighting shapes and containers. Most registered as empty or inert. A few flagged volatile, a couple still cold enough to mist the air when I passed. None matched the pattern yet. The pulse returned faint echoes—metal, glass, composite. But under it, something else. A deeper thrum, like a second signal bleeding through the scan, just out of sync. My sensors glitched, flickering once before stabilizing. I ignored it. Or tried to. My head buzzed for half a second too long, like a mosquito inside my skull. I gritted my teeth and pushed the thought aside. The mission came first. Always first. I started moving between workstations, scanning shelves, drawers, containment trays—each click of my boots sounding way too loud even above the machinery hums. I traced the edge of the table, metal cold under my fingertips. Every minute pulled at me like thick syrup. Too slow. Finally, my HUD picked it up. A faint thermal signature in the cold storage fridge a few meters ahead. Of course. Nothing worth a damn ever sits in plain view or easy access. I edged around the table, careful not to kick scattered glass or forgotten tools. Each step precise, measured. Night vision painted the room in green, thermal outlining every object like a blueprint. The vials came into view, shimmering with clear liquid slightly warmer than the cold air. My sensors hummed faint approval. My HUD flagged six of them. I scanned the area for a carrying case. There had to be one. My HUD flicked through overlays, highlighting shapes, edges, potential containers—nothing useful. A dozen sealed drawers, a few shattered trays, and a single overturned cart leaking coolant across the floor. No transport unit. No containment box. I clenched my jaw, pulse ticking behind my teeth. I didn't have any means of moving the vials safely. No one told me I'd need to. Typical. They send me in blind, expect me to improvise, and act surprised when things burn down. I crouched beside a counter, rifled through a drawer. Empty. Another—just brittle gloves and a cracked data-pad still looping a corrupted boot screen. The third offered a sliver of hope: insulated tubing, a fragment of foam packing, and the stale smell of ethanol. Useless. I tossed them aside and glanced back toward the fridge. Frost was creeping across the glass in delicate, spidering veins, each breath of the machine louder than the last. I switched to just thermal for a moment—clean lines, cold air pooling low around the floor, heat shimmering faintly from the vials inside. That faint warmth again, just enough to register wrong. Something about the temperature discrepancy clawed

at me, but I pushed it aside. I felt the tickle of static crawl up my spine—HUD interference bleeding through my implants. My vision shimmered for half a second, outlines bending, text flickering in languages I didn't know. The glitch passed, leaving a faint hum in my skull like a leftover migraine. Not again. I took a slow breath, forcing my pulse back down. Not the time. Not the place. I scanned the lab one last time, eyes lingering on a half-collapsed containment unit in the corner. Metal casing. Sealed edges. Maybe, if I could jury-rig it... The clock in my HUD ticked down another minute. I exhaled. No one told me I'd need to bring a carrying case. No one ever tells you the details until you're already in the dark, staring at something you shouldn't be touching. I grabbed the containment unit and hauled it onto the nearest counter. The casing was dented, one hinge half-broken, but it would do. I tore out the inner racks, lined the bottom with the foam packing I'd scavenged earlier. It wasn't much, but it would keep the vials cold long enough to get them topside. My hands moved fast, more muscle memory than thought—cut, repurpose, reseal. The soft hiss of coolant escaping the cracked tubing filled the air. I kept glancing back toward the fridge, measuring seconds in the rhythm of its compressor. The temperature differential on my HUD was already fluctuating; those vials weren't meant to stay exposed long. I forced my breathing steady. Fast was fine. Sloppy was fatal. Almost done. Just needed to re-seat the power coupling and I could lock the temperature loop. I leaned in, fingers working the makeshift seal, then the HUD spasmed. A sharp, jarring flicker across my vision. A yellow alert glyph blinked in the corner: MOTION DETECTED — SECTOR ENTRY POINT. "Shit." I killed the display instinctively and shoved the half-fixed containment box under the table. The metal scraped against the floor, too loud in the silence. I winced, slid it deeper, and straightened just as the door's magnetic locks disengaged with a soft thunk. The air pressure shifted—subtle but unmistakable. The door cracked open, spilling a thin slice of sterile light into the lab. I launched myself upward, servos in my legs kicking with a muted whine as I caught the ceiling's edge and pulled myself into the corner. The metal framework groaned under my weight before settling. I braced there, one hand hooked around a support pipe, boots pressed flat against the junction where wall met ceiling. My systems adjusted, compensating for the shift in balance. I killed the last traces of active HUD light—darkness swallowed everything but the soft pulse of thermal outlines bleeding through my optics. Breath slow. Muscles locked. Motionless. The door opened fully beneath me. A sliver of white light sliced across the lab floor, scattering reflections off broken glass and metal trays. Shadows moved in that beam—tall, armored, careful. Whoever they were, they knew enough to keep their weapons low and their steps measured. A faint hum reached me through the air, like the soft tuning whine of a comm unit. One voice, then another. I recognized it, it was the group from earlier. One of them swept a handheld scanner across the room. The beam passed inches from my position, painting everything below in soft UV glow. I felt the sensor pass over me, the hairs at the back of my neck prickling as the device cycled through frequencies. My armor's active camo modules adjusted automatically, dampening my thermal signature until my body heat barely registered. One of the Fomori muttered something to the other. A reply, muffled. Boots scuffed. A shadow moved closer to the fridge—their focus was on the open door, the exposed vials glinting inside. My fingers tightened around the pipe. The sound of my own pulse filled my ears, too loud, too human. I forced myself to stay still, to wait, even as the itch of adrenaline burned under my skin. One wrong twitch, and they'd look up.

Hamish

“I go no further.”

I paused mid-scribe, my pen hovering over the half-finished rune I had been working on. The sigil dimmed, its pale cyan glow guttering out as the mana-thread collapsed

The guide had already killed the engine. Silence rushed in to fill the space it left, broken only by the soft patter of rain against the vehicle’s shell. Outside, the road ended in rot and weeds, the old mag-lanes cracked and half-swallowed by mud. A single flickering lamp leaned crooked at the roadside, its light sickly and weak, barely pushing back the fog.

The guide twisted in his seat to face us. His coat was synth-leather, patched and re-patched, the collar threaded with warding wire. A chrome implant replaced one eye, its iris scrolling faint diagnostic runes. He held out his hand, palm up, fingers twitching once.

“No,” Cameron said from the back seat. He leaned forward, the glow from his wrist-rig casting sharp lines across his jaw. “We agreed fifty percent up front, fifty percent after we get back.” He craned his neck, peering past the guide through the rain-streaked windshield. “And aren’t we still, like, two miles out?”

The guide’s smile didn’t reach his eyes. “Town close enough.”

“Just pay him.” our healer said softly. She sat with her hands folded around a mana crystal at her throat. Her dark brown hair fell in waves around her shoulders, accentuated by the soft blue glow of the crystal “We’ll be okay.”

Cameron gritted his teeth. “Fine. But he leaves the vehicle here.”

For a moment, I thought the guide might argue. Instead, he shrugged, the motion loose and careless, as if none of this mattered to him anymore. Cameron slapped a pre-loaded cred-stick into his waiting palm. The guide didn’t even look at the balance before pocketing it.

“Fine by me,” he said, opening the door. Rain and cold flooded in. “Where you go is death.”

I arched an eyebrow as he left.

“Yeah, frag you too,” Cameron muttered, watching the guide’s silhouette vanish back the way we’d come.

I looked down and reactivated my work. Mana bled back into the lines as I finished the sigil, the ink flaring briefly before settling. I leaned close and blew across the page, drying it with a faint shimmer of residual energy.

“Don’t know why you don’t just use a tablet,” Cameron said, leaning over my shoulder. The glow from one of his augments washed the paper in pale blue light. “Would be faster.”

I folded the paper carefully, edges aligned, creases pressed flat with my thumb. The warmth lingered, a soft thrum pulsing through it like a heartbeat. I held it out to him.

“Can’t give it to you if it’s on there,” I said. “Also, you know tech and magic don’t mesh well.”

He took it, turning the folded sheet over in his hands, brows knitting as if he could feel the spell through the paper. “What is it?”

“Protection ward,” I answered. “We don’t know what’ll be out here.”

He shrugged, easy, like we were gearing up for a routine guard job instead of a run into a dead town. “Cool.”

“It should stop an attack from someone about your strength,” I continued, meeting his eyes, “but only once. After that, it’ll break.” I tapped the folded paper with two fingers. “I can’t keep throwing mana around. Need to conserve what I’ve got.”

“Did you do one for Milyah?” he asked.

“I’m good,” Milyah said, shaking her head slightly. “I may be specialized in healing, but I know a few defensive spells.” She glanced down at the folded ward in Cameron’s hands, then back up, offering a small smile. “And a couple offensive ones, if it comes to that. But I appreciate the thought.”

“Anyway, we came all the way out here for reconnaissance,” I said, pushing myself upright and tucking my notebook away. “All the client wants to know is why towns out here keep getting abandoned. We find the reason, get out and they’ll send a specialized team in.”

“Hey, y’all done chit-chatting up there?” a voice crackled over our Nexus comms. “It’s kinda cramped back here.”

“Oh, right.” Cameron laughed, the tension bleeding out of his voice. “Sorry, guys.”

We climbed out of the vehicle and circled around to the rear of the transport. Cameron popped the latch and hauled the door open. The seal hissed, and the remaining three members of our recon team spilled out as they stretched and swore in unison.

Jason was the first to straighten, rolling his shoulders as his Genesis armor crackled and whined, plates shifting to compensate. “Crikey,” he said, flexing his hands. “Hope this goes smoothly. I need the cred from this job if I’m ever gonna afford an upgrade.”

Dallas, our local locksmith, snorted and slugged Jason's shoulder hard enough to make the armor thump. "Damn straight. Your rig's, what, three generations behind now? I've seen museum pieces with better response time."

"Still kept me alive," Jason shot back.

"Barely," Avery said, rolling his eyes.

Avery was probably the least augmented one of us, not counting Milyah and me. No visible augments, no glowing interfaces, no obvious hardware. Just muscle. Thick, dense muscle, packed onto a frame built like a bunker. He looked human enough, but everyone who met him for more than five minutes swore he had to be half-orc.

"Pay off the Sharks first," He added flatly. "Upgrades don't mean much if you're dead in an alley."

"Yeah, yeah," Jason grouched, adjusting the tension of one of his shoulder plates. "Can't go five minutes without someone reminding me about my debt."

"If you'd stop gambling, we would stop." I said, deadpan.

Jason shot me a look, at the same time scrubbing a hand through his sandy hair. "It's not gambling if I'm good at it."

Dallas barked out a laugh. Avery just shook his head, unimpressed.

"Statistically," I added, "you're not."

That earned me a groan and another round of muttered complaints as Cameron sealed the transport back up behind us.

"Alright," Avery said. "Eyes up. Focus. No more horseplay."

He gestured toward the dark stretch of road leading into town. "We move in teams of two. Keep visual contact with your partner at all times. No heroics, no wandering off." His gaze lingered on Jason for half a second longer than necessary.

"We split to cover ground faster, sweep outward, then converge on the town center. If anything goes sideways, you fall back to your partner first, then the rally point." He nodded once, decisive. "Comms stay open. If you see something that doesn't belong, you call it."

He jerked his chin at Jason. "You're with Cameron." Then he nodded toward Dallas. "Dallas, take Milyah." Finally, his eyes landed on me. "Hamish, you're stuck with me."

I shrugged, rolling one shoulder under my coat. “Sure. Just... no one get flattened, yeah? We’ve only got one actual healer, and I’d like to keep it that way.”

“You know healing spells,” Dallas said, pointing at me like he’d caught me trying to dodge responsibility.

“I know them,” I agreed. “That’s not the same thing as being good at them.” I made a small, helpless gesture with my hands. “There’s a reason I stick to offensive and defensive work.”

Dallas opened his mouth, then thought better of it.

“I can heal,” I went on. “Technically. But the last time I tried was back in school, and the guy I was practicing on walked away with his leg put on backwards.” I paused. “Orientation was correct. Placement was not.”

There was a beat of silence.

Jason let out a sharp laugh. Milyah winced, one hand dropping instinctively to her own knee.

“So,” I finished, “let’s all try very hard not to make me practice.”

Vesper

My arms started trembling, a fine vibration crawling up from my wrists to my elbows. A light, involuntary shudder—something that shouldn't have been possible. Not with servo-stabilizers. Not with reinforced joints. Not with the obscene amount I'd paid to make sure my body did what it was told.

Ghost caught it immediately.

The feedback loop kicked in, trying to correct the motion, dumping micro-adjustments into my muscles faster than my nervous system could keep up. It overcompensated. The tremor didn't stop—it amplified. My forearms locked for half a second, fingers twitching like they'd forgotten whose hand they belonged to. Heat bloomed under the armor, sharp and electrical, nerves lighting up in confused protest.

I ground my teeth, forcing myself to stay still, to breathe shallow and slow while the system fought itself under my skin. Any sudden movement now would spike the readings. Any noise, any scrape of armor, any telltale whir—

Below me, the group kept searching.

One of the normal humans paused near the fridge, boots scuffing against the tile. Another tilted his head, scanning the ceiling on the far side of the room. Too close. Way too close. My visor dimmed my low-light automatically, like it could hide the fact that my heart was hammering hard enough to rattle my ribs.

Then one of the Fomori stopped directly beneath me.

He tilted his head, slow and deliberate, like he was listening for something he couldn't quite place. The tremor surged again, a tiny, traitorous twitch in my shoulder, and for one horrible second I was sure the armor was going to give me away—servo whine, joint click, something.

I almost let out an audible sigh of relief when the taller of the two humans finally gave the order to move on to the next room.

Almost.

The group began to peel away, their voices faded down the corridor, muffled by distance and thick walls. For half a breath, I let myself believe they were actually going to be gone.

Then the Fomori at the rear slowed.

It lingered just inside the doorway while the others continued on, its silhouette framed by the thin spill of hall light. Its head tilted slightly, as if it had felt something brush the edge of its awareness - maybe its own AI catching something it had missed. Its gaze swept the lab again, slower this time, more deliberate.

It settled on the table.

On the containment unit I'd dragged out of place—its casing warped, one hinge bent wrong, frost creeping along the seams where cold leaked into warmer air. The fridge's compressor kicked on, loud in the sudden quiet, and I had to fight the urge to flinch.

This one was built lighter than the others. Narrower shoulders. Maybe female. The armor fit her frame more closely, less brute plating and more articulation. She took a step toward the table, then another.

My pulse slammed harder, a heavy, traitorous thud. The tremor in my arms surged again, fine and vicious, servo-stabilizers fighting feedback as Ghost tried to smooth it out. Heat bloomed under the armor, nerves lighting up with static pain. I locked my jaw and focused on breathing shallow, slow—anything to keep the systems from spiking.

She stopped directly beneath me.

My panic crested—and Ghost took that, along with the subtle hitch in her posture as her chin began to lift, as permission.

Warnings flared through my implants, half-formed and already too late. Systems spun up in a silent cascade—power routing, balance correction, targeting overlays snapping into place.

I was already moving by the time my mind caught up.

Ghost took everything.

My body snapped into motion as if a string had been yanked hard enough to tear something loose. Gravity inverted, then slammed back into place as Ghost dumped my full body weight into the drop. I fell out of the ceiling like a blade, boots leading, joints screaming as actuators overrode my balance instincts.

My foot caught her under the jaw.

A blunt, bone-jarring collision that rattled up my leg and into my skull. Her armor took the worst of it, reinforced plating preventing her neck from snapping clean, but the force was enough to hurl her backward. She hit the table hard, metal shrieking as it buckled, glassware exploding in a spray of frost and shards.

Pain lagged a half-second behind the motion, then arrived all at once.

My muscles burned like they'd been flooded with acid. Ghost didn't pace the movement, wringing every ounce of force out of tendons and joints that weren't meant to move that fast or that far. Something might have torn in my shoulder. My vision flared white at the edges as my nervous system struggled to catch up with what my body had already done.

I staggered as my boots hit the floor, knees buckling. Ghost caught me mid-collapse, locking my joints before I could fall, forcing me upright with a wrenching snap that made my teeth clack together. I tasted copper.

The Fomori hit the floor hard, disoriented but not down. Armor scraped as she tried to push herself up, one hand clawing at the tile.

Too slow.

Ghost surged again, hijacking my spine, twisting my torso faster than my balance could support. The movement dragged a scream out of my throat before I could stop it, torn loose as my body protested the impossible angle. My arm came up without my permission, elbow driving down toward her head.

I felt the impact more than I heard it. A dull, wet crunch transmitted straight through my bones. The feedback screamed through my implants, pain signals stacking on top of each other until they blurred into something hot and electric and wrong.

She went limp.

I stood there for half a heartbeat afterward, shaking uncontrollably. Suddenly my hands weren't mine — fingers twitching, fingers exing, opening and closing. HUD cascaded with red nerve-override warnings as Ghost ran post-action diagnostics with zero regard for meat.

"Stop!" I screamed in my head, "Ghost, I said STOP!" Ghost wasn't supposed to do this. None of the legal firmware did.

The machine didn't listen.

Vesper

Frag.

Everything hurt.

Not the clean, sharp pain of a single wound, but a diffuse, screaming ache that lived everywhere at once—muscles overextended, joints protesting, nerves misfiring as they struggled to remember who was supposed to be in charge. My body felt wrong, like it had been wrung out and put back together slightly off-axis.

My muscles spasmed as control bled back unevenly, like a limb waking up wrong after being asleep too long.

My hands shook as I fumbled for the control panel mounted inside my thigh. Fingers didn't quite respond the way I told them to, lagging half a second behind my intent. I missed the button once, swore under my breath, then found it and pressed hard.

The injector fired.

Cold flooded my veins, sharp and invasive. The healing serum spread through me in a creeping wave, knitting just enough to keep me upright. It didn't fix anything—not really. It just stapled muscle back onto bone, muted the worst of the pain, and told my body to hold together a little longer. I could feel it working, feel things tightening that shouldn't have moved yet, scar tissue forming fast and ugly beneath the armor.

I sagged anyway, dropping to my knees as the adrenaline bled off. My breath came ragged, lungs burning. My hands clawed at the containment unit and I dragged it toward me, metal scraping loudly across the floor. Every sound felt like a flare.

I needed those vials.

I hauled the unit upright with a grunt, vision swimming as pain spiked again where Ghost had overdrawn my limits. Something in my shoulder ground unpleasantly as I moved it. I ignored it. Pain was negotiable. Failure wasn't.

I sensed them before I heard them. The other two Fomori, drawn by the noise.

A shout cut through the lab.

The instant the sound hit my ears, Ghost seized my body and yanked.

I was wrenched hard to the left, boots skidding across tile as Ghost dragged me bodily out of the line of

fire. Something tore past where I had been an instant earlier, close enough that I felt the heat of it sizzle across my forearm. Pain flared sharp and bright, then dulled as the armor absorbed the worst of it.

Too close.

Ghost didn't let me recover. It whipped my body around, spine twisting faster than it should have been able to tolerate, using the momentum to fling me behind an overturned workstation as both Fomori charged into the room.

My shoulder screamed again as Ghost forced it through the motion, grinding something that definitely wasn't supposed to grind. I bit back a cry, as my vision blurred at the edges.

One of them rounded the table too fast. Ghost shoved my body forward, low and reckless, sending me skidding across broken glass and coolant-slick tile. My knee slammed into something solid and white-hot pain exploded up my leg. Ghost ignored it.

My arm came up without my permission, driving a strike into the Fomori's chest plate—not to break it, but to test it. The impact rang through my bones and came back wrong, like punching a wall that punched back harder. The armor barely flexed.

Bad idea.

The Fomori retaliated instantly, a gauntleted fist crashing into my side hard enough to lift me off my feet. I hit the floor and slid, breath blasting out of me in a gasp. Alarms shrieked inside my skull as my implants flagged fractures, strain, damage Ghost didn't bother to acknowledge.

I felt tendons protest as it hauled my body upright by force alone, dumping power into my legs until they locked and held whether I wanted them to or not. My hands shook violently, fingers spasming as Ghost recalibrated grip strength and joint limits on the fly.

The second Fomori closed in, flanking, weapon coming up.

Ghost twisted us sideways again, barely clearing another shot. It scorched past my shoulder, close enough that the armor blistered and my skin screamed beneath it. The smell of burned polymer filled the air.

Shit.

This had gone past FUBAR. I needed an out—now.

My HUD flickered, stuttering as Ghost ripped priority control from me, again. A targeting reticle snapped onto a beaker of translucent fluid on the nearest counter, its contents flagged with half a dozen warning icons I didn't have time to read. Ghost didn't hesitate.

It just took my injured arm, wrenched it past its safe range, muscle fibers tearing with a sick, internal snap I felt more than heard. My hand closed around the beaker and Ghost hurled my body forward, dumping everything into the throw. The motion was wrong—too fast, too violent—like my arm was about to rip free entirely.

The beaker shattered against the first Fomori's visor.

Glass burst outward. The fluid splashed across the face plate and instantly began to react, smoking as it ate into the armor's surface. The Fomori reeled, clawing at his helmet as alarms screamed from his suit, visor clouding and then going opaque.

Ghost didn't stop.

It dropped my center of gravity hard, yanking me down and forward, sending me sliding between the two of them on my knees. My armor screeched across the tile, sparks spitting as something caught and tore. The movement wrenched a sound out of my throat that might've been a laugh or a sob—I couldn't tell anymore.

I reached out as I slid, fingers spasming, and Ghost forced them to clamp down on the second Fomori's weapon. The grip wasn't clean. My wrist bent the wrong way, bones shifting unpleasantly as Ghost locked it in place anyway.

I felt it all.

The Fomori shouted as the weapon tore free, my stolen momentum yanking it out of his grasp. Ghost spun us hard, using the motion to sling me past him and back onto my feet. My vision tunneled, black creeping in at the edges as my implants screamed overload warnings I didn't have time to acknowledge.

Behind me, the first Fomori was still blinded, armor shrieking as it tried to purge whatever was eating at its sensors.

Ahead of me, the second was already recovering.

My body trembled violently, micro-seizures rippling through muscle groups Ghost had pushed too far, too fast. My hands wouldn't stop shaking. I was built to take punishment—had paid a small fortune for that privilege—but not like this. Not with my own systems turning on me.

Gods, I'd need to pay someone—anyone—to rip Ghost out of my head once this was over. A licensed specialist, a rogue tech, some back-alley butcher with more confidence than ethics. I didn't care.

I didn't get the chance to linger on the thought—not with Ghost still tracking active targets.

The second Fomori lunged.

He came in fast, armor-assisted speed turning the lab into a blur of motion and impact. Slower than say my armor but with how battered I was, it might as well be the same.

Ghost barely got my body out of the way again, wrenching me sideways as a fist smashed into the space where my head had been. The shock wave rattled my teeth anyway, a concussive thump that made my vision strobe.

My stolen weapon came up too late.

The Fomori slammed into me shoulder-first, driving me back into a counter hard enough to buckle steel. Something in my back popped with a sickening sensation, and pain detonated up my spine. Ghost cut the worst of it, throttling pain signals down to something manageable, something survivable, but the damage was still there—stacking, waiting.

I fired at point-blank range.

The shot sparked off Aegis plating, carving a shallow groove but failing to penetrate. The recoil tore at my already abused shoulder, and my grip faltered as my fingers spasmed.

The Fomori grabbed the barrel and twisted.

Ghost screamed through my nervous system—let go—and yanked my hand free before the weapon could be turned on me. My wrist bent wrong again, ligaments stretching too far, too fast. I felt something tear and didn't have time to care.

Behind him, the first Fomori staggered blindly, clawing at his visor as the unknown fluid continued to eat at his sensors. His armor vented in short, angry bursts, internal systems cycling hard as they tried to compensate. He fired wildly, shots carving glowing scars across walls and ceiling, one beam slicing through a hanging light strip and plunging half the lab into darkness.

Ghost used it.

It dragged me low, forcing my body into a slide across the floor again. It burned my palms as I skidded, heat and pain flaring as the armor took the worst of it. My legs kicked out, sweeping the second Fomori's feet—not to knock him down, but to unbalance him just enough.

Just enough was all Ghost needed.

It surged forward, dumping everything I had left into a brutal, reckless strike aimed at the joint behind his knee. The impact rang up my bones like a struck bell. Aegis armor resisted—but not completely. Something inside the joint failed with a grinding snap, and the Fomori went down hard, armor shrieking in protest.

Ghost didn't let him recover. Driving me forward, mounting him, raining blows into vulnerable seams—neck ring, under-arm articulation, visor edge. Each hit cost me something: a spike of white-hot pain, a fresh tremor, a creeping numbness in my left hand that refused to go away.

A shot screamed past my head.

The first Fomori, still half-blind, firing on sound alone.

Ghost twisted us yet again, hauling me off the downed Fomori just as another blast chewed a molten crater through the floor where my skull had been. My landing was ugly, knees slamming down, joints locking to keep me upright as my body tried to fold.

The second Fomori didn't get back up.

I didn't check how badly he was hurt. I didn't have the luxury.

The first Fomori staggered closer, visor cracked and flickering, armor venting smoke and chemical stench as the unknown fluid continued to foul his systems. He roared something unintelligible and charged, blind and furious.

My entire body shook. There was no way I could survive this.

Ghost knew it too.

There was no clever angle left, no clean strike, no remaining margin it could squeeze out of broken muscle and over stressed servos. Every projection collapsed into the same red certainty: if he reached me, he would pulp me. Armor or not.

So Ghost stopped trying to fight him.

It turned the lab itself into the weapon.

My HUD flared hard enough to hurt as Ghost rerouted power, dumping everything into my legs and spinal actuators in a way that made my vision tunnel. I screamed—not from pain exactly, but from the sensation of my body being pulled forward faster than my organs wanted to move.

I ran.

Not away.

Straight at him.

The Fomori swung blindly, a massive arc meant to crush bone and armor alike. Ghost dragged me under

it, so low my shoulder scraped the floor, sparks tearing free as plating ground against tile. My ribs screamed. Something else cracked. I tasted blood.

Then Ghost twisted.

It used the Fomori's own momentum, hooked my body into his center of mass, and drove us both into the containment rack behind him. Metal screamed. The rack collapsed sideways, slamming into his back and pinning one arm at an ugly angle. His roar cut off into a strangled, metallic snarl as Aegis plating locked up, servos fighting sudden misalignment.

He never got a chance to recover.

It forced my shaking hands to grab his gun, ignoring the way my fingers barely responded, and slammed the stolen weapon into the gap where his visor had already cracked. I felt resistance—then a sharp give as damaged systems failed catastrophically.

The shot went off.

At that range, through compromised armor, it didn't have to be precise.

The Fomori convulsed, armor spasming as internal safeties died in a cascade. He sagged forward, weight dragging me down with him. Ghost barely managed to shove us clear before his body hit the floor like a dropped machine.

Silence slammed into the lab.

I collapsed to my knees anyway, systems finally giving up the lie. My hands shook so badly I couldn't keep them clenched. My vision fractured at the edges, HUD stuttering as Ghost relinquished just enough control to keep me conscious.

Get the vials. Get Out.

I stumbled over to the fridge—somehow still standing despite everything—and braced myself against it. My right arm hung useless at my side, numb and burning at the same time, nerves firing in confused, delayed bursts. I used the other one—the mostly intact one—to hook my fingers around the handle and pull.

Cold air spilled out, sharp and clean, fogging around my visor. The sudden temperature change sent a fresh spike of pain through my joints, and I hissed through my teeth, forcing myself to stay upright. I leaned in, vision swimming, and squinted through the mist until the interior came into focus.

The vials were still there.

Six of them, nestled in their racks like nothing had happened. Blue liquid, faintly luminous, each one humming with a low thermal signature that prickled uncomfortably at the back of my skull. Project: Archangel. I didn't let myself think about what that meant.

My hand shook as I reached in. Fingers slipped on frost the first time. I swore, adjusted my grip, and tried again, carefully this time. The rack came loose with a soft click.

I forced my breathing into an even rhythm and kept moving.

The back access hallway was narrow and poorly lit, strips of half-dead LEDs flickering overhead. Condensation traced the walls, and the whole place smelled like coolant and sterilized metal. Every step sent a dull jolt up my legs, pain lagging half a beat behind motion like my body was struggling to keep up with itself.

I palmed the exit panel, overriding it with a stolen authorization code. The panel hesitated—then unlocked. I slipped through and stepped out into the night.

Cold air hit me like a slap.

I jogged across the cracked pavement behind the facility, keeping low between abandoned loading crates and rust-flaked machinery. The city lights buzzed faintly in the distance, a smear of neon through the low-lying fog. Somewhere far off, a siren wailed.

Maybe for me.

Maybe not.

Didn't matter.

I wasn't sticking around to find out.

The drop point was four blocks away, tucked under a collapsed sky bridge at the edge of Old District where cameras were either broken or hacked into. I stuck to the shadows, using the clutter of ruined architecture as cover. The containment unit thumped lightly against my hip with every stride, a steady reminder of what I was carrying—and what it would cost if I dropped it.

My pace slowed despite me telling it not to. My legs felt thick, unresponsive, like they were moving through syrup. My vision tunneled briefly, black flickering at the edges, and I had to stop myself from pitching forward.

Not yet.

At the mouth of the alley, I slowed.

Scanned.

Listened.

Just the hum of distant transformers and the quiet drip of water falling from fractured concrete overhead.

The drop box was where it always was—buried behind a sheet of old metal siding, disguised as part of a collapsed support beam. I keyed in the pass code with numb fingers, missing one digit and having to start over.

The containment unit slid inside.

The lock hissed shut, internal clamps sealing with a final, decisive thunk.

Done.

The word barely registered before my knees buckled.

I caught myself against a concrete pillar, armor scraping loudly as I sagged into it. My heart hammered erratically, too fast, too shallow. When I tried to straighten, my body didn't listen. My good arm shook violently, fingers curling and uncurling without permission.

My HUD pinged—a soft blue reminder.

MISSION COMPLETE. AWAIT FURTHER INSTRUCTIONS.

I let out something between a laugh and groan of pain.

“Yeah,” I muttered, forehead resting against cold concrete. “How about you stay the hell out of my body next time?”

Ghost didn't respond.

Good.

The world tilted anyway.

The alley lights smeared into long, pale streaks as my vision finally gave up the fight. The last thing I felt was the chill of the concrete seeping through my armor.

Then everything went dark.

Hamish

Avery and I jogged the two miles toward the town alongside the others, the transport shrinking behind us until it vanished into fog. The road was uneven and half-reclaimed by weeds, forcing us to watch our footing as much as the dark shapes ahead. Rain slicked everything, soaking through boots and fabric, turning the run into a steady grind instead of a sprint.

It took us about twenty minutes.

By the time we slowed near the edge of town, Dallas was bent over with his hands on his knees, breathing hard, rain dripping off the end of his nose. His face had gone a little too pale under the streetlight glow, augments or not.

Jason, on the other hand, looked irritated more than tired. Barely winded. Of course he did. The bastard probably could've done it in ten, probably less if he'd been allowed to open up.

I wiped rain out of my eyes and glanced around as we split up. The town looked like it had once been a nice place. Not city nice, but about as good as it got out here near the Port city of Cyrene. Clean lines once. Thought put into it. Someone had cared enough to try.

Most of the buildings were low and sturdy, built to last rather than impress. Wide doorways. Reinforced frames. A lot of stone mixed in with prefab. The walls were thick, scarred by weather and time, but still standing.

The graffiti told the rest of the story.

Bold lines. Heavy strokes. Clan marks layered over each other, some faded, some sharp and angry. Names, symbols, territorial tags. Orc work, mostly. You could always tell.

Probably been an orc town, once. Or mostly orcs, anyway.

Electricity still sputtered in places, stubborn as a bad habit. Neon signs flickered at random intervals, casting broken color across empty streets—red, then blue, then nothing at all. A pawn shop sign buzzed like an angry insect before going dark. Somewhere farther in, a light snapped on for half a second and died again.

Avery gave a brief hand signal, two fingers forward, then a sharp cut up the street. I acknowledged with a nod and moved in behind him, matching his pace.

I kept most of my mana tightly contained, letting only a thin stream leak through to sustain a low-level shield spell. It settled over me like a second skin, barely visible, just enough to take the edge off anything sudden without lighting me up like a flare.

We paused beside a corner building, its windows boarded over with uneven sheets of old wood. Some were warped from moisture, others split outright. One board had cracked down the middle, just enough to let a thin sliver of neon bleed through the gap.

ARCADE.

The sign was missing two letters. The remaining ones flickered weakly, stuttering on and off like they weren't convinced they still had a purpose anymore. Each pulse painted the street in brief washes of color before sinking back into shadow.

Rain hissed where it struck exposed wiring above the doorway, steam curling up in thin, ghostly threads. The door had once been glass. Now it was cracked and webbed, reinforced with a rusted security grate. The grate had been torn open and bent back by hand, metal twisted and peeled away like it hadn't offered much resistance.

Recent.

The edges were still sharp, bright where the rust hadn't had time to settle in.

Avery slowed and raised a fist.

I stopped with him as he tapped his comm and did a quick check-in. "Everyone, status."

For a moment there was only rain and the low buzz of the arcade sign. Then the Nexus crackled to life as the others began sounding off, one by one. Short updates. Locations. Just enough to let us know they were still upright and breathing.

Avery listened without comment, eyes never leaving the street ahead, his posture loose but ready.

"Let's check out this arcade." He said. "It seems odd that this place is one of the few places still with some semblance of power."

When we stepped inside, it was like stepping back in time a couple centuries.

Retro arcade cabinets lined the walls in uneven rows, their plastic shells scuffed and yellowed with age, marquees flickering through boot cycles that should've died decades ago. Pixel displays buzzed softly, colors bleeding at the edges. Joysticks worn smooth by hands long gone. Some of the machines still bore old stickers and etched names, memorials disguised as vandalism.

Interspersed among them was newer hardware—too new for a place like this. VR pods crouched between cabinets, matte-black shells patched and re-patched, neural ports dangling on reinforced cables. A few full-dive rigs sat open, gel cushions cracked but clean, like they were still being used.

As we walked through warily, a few of the machines lay smashed open, their electronic guts spilling out onto the floor. Exposed boards sparked intermittently, tiny blue arcs snapping through the gloom. The smell hit a second later—burnt circuitry mixed with some gods-awful smell. Like something had died and been left

Several cabinets were coated in a thick, oily substance that clung to their surfaces in uneven sheets, pooling beneath them.

Curiosity got the better of me. I crouched, leaning closer, and reached out to drag a finger lightly through the liquid.

“Hey!” Avery barked, smacking my hand aside before I could make contact. “Probably not wise to touch unknown fluids with bare hands.”

I straightened slowly, flexing my fingers. “Too be fair I know several decontamination spells.”

“If they’re anything like your knowledge of healing spells, I’d rather not tempt fate.”

I straightened slowly, flexing my fingers. “To be fair, I know several decontamination spells.”

Avery shot me a sideways look, unimpressed. “If they’re anything like your knowledge of healing magic, I’d rather not tempt fate.”

I huffed a quiet laugh despite myself. “Hey, that was one time. And besides, decontamination is just killing things at a microscopic scale. I’m good at killing things.”

“Sure you are,” he said, eyes already back on the room, scanning the dark between cabinets.

The Nexus crackled. “This is Jason and Cameron checking in.” Jason’s voice cut through the static.

“Go ahead,” Avery said.

“We’re in what looks like it used to be an upgrade shop,” Jason reported.

“Or a chop shop,” Cameron added.

“Whatever,” Jason said, irritation bleeding through. “Everything’s smashed to hell. Looks like a lot of gear’s missing, too.”

“Junkies probably hit it,” I offered. “Strip what they could carry, break what they couldn’t.”

“Maybe,” Jason said, his voice carrying a note of doubt. “But there’s this... weird goo coating a lot of what’s left.”

Avery's eyes flicked to the slick, glossy patches around our feet.

"What kind of goo?" he asked.

There was an uncomfortable pause.

"Don't know," Jason said. "Dark. Oily. Same stuff on the walls, the counters."

Avery and I exchanged a look.

"Don't touch the goo," Avery said into the Nexus, his voice firm. "Understood?"

"Copy that," Jason said.

"Copy," Cameron echoed a half-second later.

Avery nodded once, more to himself than anyone else. "Dallas. Milyah. You get that?"

"Loud and clear," Dallas replied without hesitation.

When the comms went quiet again, I took another slow look around the arcade.

"Client'll probably want samples," I said.

Avery didn't argue. He shrugged his bag off his shoulder and set it down on a relatively clean patch of floor, nudging aside debris with the toe of his boot first. He knelt and rummaged through it, producing a box of rubber gloves, a couple of narrow test-tube vials, and two disposable scoop sticks—the cheap Popsicle-type ones meant for exactly this kind of thing.

We both pulled on gloves.

Up close, the substance looked thicker than I'd expected. Dark, glossy, clinging to itself instead of spreading out. It caught the flickering neon light and warped it, like oil on water but heavier.

"This stuff looks almost like the oil they used in old-era cars," I said.

Avery grunted. "Yeah. Before everything went electric."

I watched the way the goo stretched slightly as he scooped a small amount into a vial. "Except for military-grade ones."

I passed the vials I filled back to Avery and rose from my crouch, careful not to slosh anything inside them. As I straightened, I thought I caught movement out of the corner of my eye—just a blur where there shouldn't have been one, gone the instant I tried to focus on it.

Avery finished capping the vials and tucked them back into his bag. He glanced up at me, eyes narrowing just a touch. “What’s wrong, Hamish?” he asked. “You’re more twitchy than Jason when his armor glitches and that’s saying something.”

“I thought I saw something, but it’s probably nothing.” I muttered.

Avery arched an eyebrow, studying me for a moment instead of dismissing it outright. “No.” he said finally. “I trust your intuition sometimes better than my own.” He reached back and drew his gun from its holster.

I passed Avery a piece of paper similar to the one I’d given Cameron earlier, except this one had a fire-lance spell inscribed on it. “To be safe,” I said while preparing my own spell as we moved in the direction where I’d seen the movement.

We made our way toward the back of the building, footsteps soft against the littered floor. The storage room was tucked away behind the arcade proper, half-hidden by broken machines and collapsed shelving. Its door hung open crookedly, suspended from a single hinge, swaying slightly whenever the air shifted.

Avery slowed and took a cautious step forward, peering into the room. He leaned just enough to get a look inside, careful not to silhouette himself in the doorway.

“Hamish,” he whispered. “Come here.”

What first caught my attention as I stepped up beside him was that the horrid stench had grown overpowering. It hit the back of my throat all at once, and I instinctively covered my nose with one hand as I followed the line of his pointing finger with my gaze.

The room was a mess of smashed machinery. Broken cabinets and torn-open hardware lay scattered everywhere, some of them still stubbornly holding power. Loose cables and wires sparked and twitched where they hung, light flickering erratically across the space. But at the center of the room, amid the wreckage, was a figure hunched over.

In the flickering light, I could barely make it out. Broad shoulders. Heavy build. It looked like an orc.

I squinted a little, trying to make out more details, or at least pinpoint the source of the smell. It seemed to cling to everything in the room, thick enough that it was hard to tell whether it was coming from the machinery, the floor, or the figure itself.

Avery leaned a little too far forward, shifting his weight. His shoulder bumped the door, nudging it just enough to set it swinging. The hinges protested immediately, letting out a long, dry squeal as metal scraped against metal, far too loud in the stillness of the room.

I caught Avery before he could stumble, fingers digging into his sleeve to steady him. We both froze in place, instinct taking over, eyes locked on the orc in the center of the room.

The orc shifted slightly, just enough to tell me it had heard us. My breath hitched slightly but it steadied again when they didn't even bother to look our way.

I let out a shaky huff of relief as Avery recovered his balance, muttering a curse under his breath. When I glanced back, the orc was no longer still. Its movements were small, restless—agitated. It began tearing at one of its own arms, claws scraping against flesh and metal alike.

Chunks of skin started to slough away beneath its claws. Under, the flesh was wrong dark, threaded with dull wires that pulsed faintly as if they were still alive. The smell hit a second later: hot iron and rot, like burning meat left too long on a coil. My stomach lurched. It was like watching a slow-motion mag train wreck, every instinct screaming to look away, but I couldn't.

The orc pawed clumsily through the debris around it, fingers slick with that liquid that coated everything, rummaging through broken electronics until it found what it wanted: a shattered VR core, its casing split open, wires spilling out like exposed nerves.

It pressed the core against the ruined remains of its arm.

The loose wires began to twitch.

I felt a crawling panic as strands tore free from the orc's existing implants, slithering outward on their own, writhing like parasites drawn to a host. They stitched themselves into the broken core, burrowing deep, disappearing beneath torn flesh with sickening purpose.

The orc convulsed. Its body locked, then arched, as the core flared to life—glowing faintly, hungrily. Light bled through skin as the wires fused, sinking inward, pulling the device closer until it was part of the arm.

Then it turned toward us.

The lights in the room finally flared—too bright, too late—holding steady just long enough for us to really see it.

Its gaze was milky white, clouded over and unfocused, like something that hadn't needed sight in a long time. The eyes didn't track us so much as point in our direction, glassy and wrong, filmed over as if something had boiled them from the inside.

Up close, it looked long dead.

Rot had set in unevenly, flesh sagging and splitting where the implants had warped it from within, clearly

carrying the body now more than the other way around.

One side of its jaw was simply gone, torn away down to yellowed bone. Teeth jutted out at unnatural angles, some cracked, some fused together by blackened residue. Every time it moved, the exposed bone scraped wetly against ruined muscle with a sound that made my skin crawl.

What skin remained was stretched thin in areas almost translucent, threaded with dim lines of light that pulsed out of sync with its breathing, if that ragged hitching could even be called breathing anymore. The glow leaked through holes in its face and neck, illuminating the inside of its mouth when it opened it too wide, like a grin it no longer understood how to control.

It lunged.

Not with the clean, brutal speed an orc should have. There was a hitch at the start, a fraction of a second where its body seemed to hesitate, before it surged like a puppet being yanked forward on strings. The delay almost fooled me. Almost.

“Shit!” Avery swore as he lurched backward nearly losing balance again. “Hamish retreat!”

Vesper

The sharp sting of antiseptic snapped me back into myself.

Consciousness returned in fragments—sensation first, then pain. My head felt wrong, heavy and distant, like it was floating just above my body instead of attached to it. My HUD stayed dark, blessedly silent, leaving me alone with the ache blooming behind my eyes.

I blinked awake, squinting hard against fluorescent lights glaring down from overhead. They hummed faintly, the sound vibrating straight through my skull. A spike of pain lanced through my head, sharp and immediate, before dulling into a deep, throbbing ache that settled in and made itself comfortable.

One that matched the rest of my body.

Where the frag am I?

I tried to sit up.

Nothing happened.

Panic hit fast and hot. My thoughts surged forward, but my body stayed exactly where it was, heavy and unresponsive. For one terrifying second I was sure I'd been scooped up by chop-shop junkies while I was out cold, strapped down and halfway disassembled.

Restrained.

I sucked in a sharp breath and tried again, harder this time—move, damn you—but my torso didn't even twitch.

My heart started to race.

I forced myself to slow down, to test things piece by piece instead of all at once. I focused on my arm. Willed it to lift.

It moved.

Perfectly normal, smooth and responsive.

That only made it worse.

Confusion crawled up my spine as I lowered it again and tried to sit up a second time. Still nothing. No pain spike, no resistance, like the signal was being swallowed before it ever reached my muscles.

My confusion only intensified with that. Again, I lifted a hand and it responded just fine. I wasn't getting any notifications that there was irreparable damage that would prevent me from sitting up. My body just refused to respond.

A soft chime sounded in my ear, gentle and unobtrusive. The type of sound meant to soothe someone terrified out of their mind. Green text bloomed into existence across my vision as my HUD flickered back online.

PLEASE REMAIN STILL FOR YOUR OWN Health.

"What?" My voice came out hoarse, scraped raw like I'd been screaming or breathing bad air. Maybe both.

I tried to sit up again. Nothing. My legs might as well have belonged to someone else. I could feel them—pressure, warmth, the faint hum of internal systems—but no matter how hard I pushed, they refused to respond.

Panic came all at once, a rush of heat and noise and awful certainty that I was trapped. Thoughts stacked on top of each other too fast to separate—move, sit up, something's wrong, get up—each one more frantic than the rest, insisting I was running out of time.

I strained against my own body again, every muscle screaming for movement that never came. The fear spiked higher, sharp enough to make my vision blur.

I didn't notice right away, but then realization slowly crept in. I lifted my hands, they should have been shaking, but they were still. Not even a slight tremor. I placed a hand against my chest finding my heartbeat but still nothing. It rose and fell normally. No trace of my inward panic showing.

What the frag...?

"Please calm down." A calm, male voice said, somewhere off to my left. "You'll undo everything we fixed if you keep it up."

I turned my head as far as it would go and caught sight of a man in a lab coat standing beside the bed. Middle-aged, neatly groomed, posture relaxed. Calm down? Was he crazy? Panic was clawing at the inside of my skull and he was talking to me like I was a malfunctioning piece of equipment.

"Where am I?" I demanded, voice edged with strain. "Why can't I move?"

"You're in a private hospital," he answered, unbothered by my tone. "We received a distress ping and picked you up. You were in awful condition." His gaze flicked briefly over me before settling back on my face. "You really overdid it."

“I overdid it?” I scoffed. “This armor malfunctioned, overrode my control.”

The doctor didn’t bat an eye. “You hit your head pretty hard when you passed out,” he said. “You must’ve imagined it.” His tone stayed level as he wrote something on a tablet. “The armor can’t override what its user instructs. That kind of safeguard failure simply isn’t possible.”

I attempted to sit up again, stubborn now, determined to prove him wrong. This time my body responded without resistance—muscles engaging smoothly, joints cooperating like nothing had ever been wrong. There was no pressure, no invisible hand holding me down. No sign of whatever had pinned me in place before.

“I never sent out a distress signal,” I said, watching his face carefully.

“No,” he agreed easily. “But your armor has a built-in one. If either it or you sustain too much damage, it alerts us automatically.” He spoke like he was reciting standard procedure. “Your benefactor would not have been pleased if you’d died.”

My lip curled slightly at the word benefactor. Loan Shark. He meant the loan shark i had borrowed money from. I’d needed the upgrade if I had wanted to continue taking jobs and raising the funds to figure out what happened to my brothers.

“So I can go, right?” I asked. I had already mentally mapped the fastest route out of this room but I figured I’d try the polite route first.

“Not just yet.” He said smoothly. “Your benefactor wishes to speak with you before you leave.”

Almost on cue the door hissed open and a man dressed in an suit that probably cost as much if not more than Ghost entered.

Vince Morrow was tall — not broad, but wiry in the way of someone who had survived more fights than he’d won. Muscle clung to his frame like tension, all lean lines and coiled restraint. Ink crawled up his throat in layered bands and symbols, street marks that no clinic could erase and no corporation would tolerate. They told a history written in alleys and broken neon, a life that hadn’t been bought — only endured.

Two bodyguards flanked him.

I had to look away.

Same height. Same shaved scalps, each broken only by a narrow ridge of dark brown hair running from brow to nape. Same matte-black ocular implants humming faintly where eyes should have reflected light.

Their coats hung open just enough to reveal identical subdermal plating along the ribs — geometric

ridges pressing against synthetic skin like something trying to escape.

It wasn't the symmetry that made my skin crawl.

It was the absence.

No fidgeting. No scanning glances. No human boredom or irritation. Just that fixed, forward orientation, as if they existed only in relation to Morrow, like weapons waiting for a trigger pull.

One of them twitched.

Not a natural movement. A sharp, mechanical correction, like a marionette jerked by a string. For a split second his fingers curled inward, nails biting into his own palm hard enough to dent this flesh. Then the tremor stopped, and he returned to perfect stillness.

Morrow's eyes were a flat, dark gray — cold and assessing. They held more shadow than the sketchiest corners of New Seattle, weighing people the way you weighed investments: by risk, by return, by how easily they could be written off. There was no curiosity in them, no recognition, just calculation — the quiet certainty of a man who had already decided your value before you spoke.

"Vesper, my friend," he said with a smile as he sat down, smoothing the front of his suit with a casual precision that suggested the gesture was more habit than necessity. I didn't miss the way he deliberately avoided the traditional word for friend — the fractional pause where it should have been, the choice to substitute something that sounded close enough to pass in polite company. "Feeling better?"

His bodyguards remained standing behind him.

I didn't look directly at them.

I wasn't in the mood for his courtesy. The smile, the tone, the careful modulation of concern — all of it was packaging, a veneer laid over the simple fact that this was a transaction and I was the commodity. My jaw tightened before I could stop it.

"What do you want, Morrow?"

"I just came to check in on my investment," he said, folding one leg over the other with unhurried ease. "You could have died if my team hadn't found you in time."

For a second, something in his voice told me that might have been the better option. The thought didn't scare me the way it probably should have. It didn't even feel dramatic. Just... practical. A quiet exit. No more contracts masquerading as favors. No more people tallying my worth against what I could survive for them.

Dying would've been simple. No more ledgers. No more interest accruing on mistakes I didn't remember making. No more waking up in rooms that smelled like antiseptic and someone else's money.

The thought lingered longer than it should have, settling into the corners of my mind like it belonged there.

I forced it down before it could root itself, before it could start making sense. I reminded myself who I was actually doing this for — the only thing that didn't fit neatly into Morrow's accounting. That was the only reason I was still here, still breathing air I couldn't afford.

"I suppose you're looking for a thank you?" I asked the sarcasm laid on thick enough to keep him at arm's length.

"You and I both know you wouldn't," he replied, the faint curve of his smile never wavering. He said it like a compliment. Like my ingratitude was a trait he'd paid extra for.

"Then stop dancing around the real reason you're here," I said. Talking hurt. Everything hurt.

The doctors noted something I thought would be wise to bring to your attention."

Of course they did. Doctors didn't note things unless those things could be itemized and billed. I rolled my eyes, already bracing for another entry on the growing list of what I owed him — another procedure, another complication, another excuse to tighten the leash.

"You've heard of Senamashi?" he asked.

I nodded. Of course I had. Senamashi was one of those words that got thrown around by academics, mystics, and street docs alike—a catch-all for essence, for humanity, for whatever invisible thing separated people from machines. It was what let certain people use magic. What made humans—and most other beings—people instead of just flesh and hardware.

"You realize your Senamashi has dropped to a dangerously low level?" he pressed, voice calm, clinical — like he was discussing blood pressure or market fluctuations. "Any lower and you risk cyberpsychosis. Beyond that..." He let the rest hang, unfinished, as if the word humanity were too sentimental to say out loud.

Beyond that, there was nothing to come back to.

"What's it to you?" I demanded my voice edged with something brittle and defensive. I didn't care if he decided I was no longer worth the trouble. Didn't care if he wrote me off, reclaimed his investment, and I ended up like the two figures standing behind him — upright, functional, and hollowed out into something that served without ever being.

He leaned back in the chair, not far, just enough to ease the pressure from his spine. The leather shifted under him. One of his cuff links caught the light when he adjusted his wrist, a small, unnecessary movement that drew the eye anyway.

“Nothing.”

The word landed flat between us.

I stared at him for a beat, waiting for the rest of it to arrive. With Morrow, there was always a second clause. A condition. A hook buried in the quiet.

“Is that all?”

He didn’t answer right away. His gaze slid past me toward the doctor. Then returned, cool and unreadable. He looked at people the way brokers looked at volatile markets: not with emotion, but with contingency plans.

“Nothing but a reminder of what you still owe,” he said at last. “And this hospital visit has been added, of course.”

Of course.

The thought surfaced with a tired twist that might once have been humor. Because nothing in this damn city was ever free.

Hamish

Avery and I skidded to a stop in the town center. I doubled over, hands braced on my knees, breathing hard. My lungs burned. I'd cast a speed-boost spell on us during the run, and it had taken a solid chunk out of my mana. Between that and the sprint itself, my legs felt like jello, like they might fold if I straightened too fast. I needed a minute. Just a minute to recover.

A few minutes later, Jason and Cameron rounded the corner of one of the houses at a jog, slowing as they spotted us. Their eyes flicked over our posture, the way Avery was standing too stiff, the way I still hadn't fully caught my breath.

"What's going on?" Cameron demanded.

Dallas and Milyah joined them moments later, the group closing in around us.

"We found one of the inhabitants," Avery said.

"That's good, right?" Milyah asked. The hope in her voice didn't quite survive the look on my face. Her expression faltered as she really saw me.

"How bad?" Jason asked, his gaze narrowing.

I dug a small recovery potion out of my bag, fingers fumbling slightly as fatigue caught up with me, while Avery began explaining what we had seen. The vial felt almost slipped from my tired fingers as I worked the stopper free, my attention split between the conversation and the dull ache behind my eyes.

"Hold up," Dallas cut in, one hand lifting as he interrupted. "Y'all saw what appeared to be a zombie, for lack of a better term, and you let it live? That's like the number one mistakes in any horror film I've ever seen." His eyes flicked between Avery and me, sharp and searching. "Are we sure that goop we've been seeing everywhere hasn't affected your brain and y'all didn't just hallucinate that?"

The words barely left Dallas's mouth before Avery wheeled on him, shoulders squared, jaw tight, ready to tear into him.

When the sound hit.

A high-pitched shriek tore through the town center, sharp enough to feel like it went straight through bone. It wasn't just loud—it was wrong, the pitch wobbling and warping as it dragged on. Something like a dying animal stretched over metal, layered with the shrill scrape of several tons of steel being hauled across concrete. Nails on a chalkboard didn't even come close.

Hands flew to ears. Teeth clenched. Someone screamed—not from fear, but pure pain. I tasted copper as

my jaw locked up, pressure building behind my eyes like they were about to burst.

Jason went down hard.

He dropped to one knee with a string of curses, the words tearing out of him as if forced, and his armor flickered violently. Sparks spat along the seams of his plating, brief arcs of white-blue light snapping and dying like his systems were fighting to stay alive. For a split second, it looked like his entire rig might shut down right there.

Like he'd just walked through an EMP blast.

The shriek died as abruptly as it had begun, the sound cutting off mid-agony and leaving behind a hollow, ringing silence as the creature staggered, its movements hitching like something inside it had burned out.

“What the ever-lovin’ hell was that?” Cameron managed, his voice raw and hoarse.

Milyah and I exchanged a glance. My ears were ringing, sharp and high, but I could still hear—still think. Pain, yeah. Damage, probably. But nothing catastrophic.

Avery straightened slowly, muscles tight beneath his gear, jaw clenched so hard I could see veins almost popping. The fury in his eyes hadn’t dimmed.

Cameron and Dallas weren’t as lucky.

Both of them winced, fingers twisting into their ears as if they could physically dig the sound back out.

“Think my comm just shorted out,” Dallas muttered, blinking hard. He tapped the side of his head, then hissed and stopped when it clearly didn’t help.

Jason hadn’t fared any better. He stayed on one knee, breathing hard, hand braced against the ground like he needed the support just to stay upright. His armor had gone dull and inert, lights dead, systems clearly offline.

I moved to him and dropped beside him. “You good?”

He looked up slowly, face tight with pain, jaw working as he swallowed back another curse. His eyes were unfocused for a second, like the world hadn’t quite settled yet, then he forced a breath through his teeth.

“Yeah,” he said. “Yeah... just need to reboot Genesis, then I should be okay.”

Jason initiated a reboot cycle on his armor, standing still while Genesis powered down and began cycling back online. Lights dimmed across his plating, status indicators scrolling through diagnostics as internal

systems reset. It would only take a few seconds—but until it finished, he was effectively grounded.

From the way Avery shifted from foot to foot, I could tell Jason being out of commission bothered him. His gaze kept flicking back to Jason, jaw tight, like he was already running through worst-case scenarios.

I rose from my crouch and kept my attention outward, scanning the town center, the collapsed buildings, the dark gaps where streets disappeared between ruined stone. My mana had finally finished recovering, thankfully, and I prepared a defense spell just in case.

Something shifted at the edge of my vision, half-hidden between collapsed structures. I turned towards the movement, in time to see another one of those creatures charge at us.

“Cover Jason!” Avery yelled.

I rammed Jason from the side, shoulder slamming into his chest with a jolt that rattled my teeth. The impact barely moved him at first but then his footing went and we went with it, stumbling hard out of the creature’s path as metal scraped stone and my shoulder screamed in protest.

Before anyone else could even react, Cameron moved.

His gun was already in his hand, two shots cracked through the air in rapid succession, both hitting the creature square in the head. The impacts snapped its skull back, momentum bending it backward like the force should have dropped it flat.

But it didn’t fall.

Instead, it snapped upright again with a sound halfway between a shriek and a roar—raw, enraged, and very much alive. Whatever Cameron had just put bullets into did not care about normal rules of anatomy or physics. Its posture straightened unnaturally, joints popping back into place as if pain was just another inconvenience.

“Fuckin’ hell,” Jason swore as we disentangled ourselves and staggered upright. He shoved himself back onto his feet, armor finally finishing its reboot with a low, rising whine as lights flickered back to life across his plating. Systems chimed in sequence, one by one, until the suit locked fully into place again.

“I hate it when problems can’t be solved with bullets,” he muttered, rolling his shoulders like he was testing the armor’s limits.

Milyah had already thrown up a shield spell between us and the creature. To the unaided eye it was virtually invisible, nothing more than empty air, but to my sight it showed itself as a faint distortion, like heat shimmer rising off sun-baked asphalt. The space it occupied wavered subtly, bending the light just enough that I could track its edge if I focused.

The others spread out, forming a loose semicircle in front of her. Weapons came up, stances set, each of them placing themselves between Milyah and the thing.

The rain started to come down heavier, lowering visibility drastically as it sheeted across the ground and blurred the world beyond a few dozen feet. The creature stayed just at the edge of our visual field, never fully committing to view. It spun back to face us, those unblinking, cloudy eyes stared at us like they could still see through the downpour—and maybe they could.

It stood there briefly, unnaturally still, before it suddenly dropped to all fours. There was an awful cracking and tearing sound, wet and mechanical at the same time, as its arms forcibly elongated. Bones and sinew separated under the strain, joints reconfiguring as black oil oozed down exposed cables and wires that bridged that sudden gap.

Its sides heaved in a mockery of breathing, each shudder like a malfunctioning mechanical toy. Its ruined jaws hung half-parted as electricity danced between its teeth, sizzling and steaming where the rain made contact, leaving the air sharp with the smell of ozone and burnt metal.

“Hamish!” Avery shouted over the rain.

I half turned toward him but kept one eye locked on the creature, afraid it would vanish if I looked away for even a second.

“Yeah?”

“We’ll distract that thing, then you hit it with the biggest spell you’ve got!” He yelled.

Even before he had finished his sentence, I was already prepping said spell, fingers moving out of habit as mana gathered at my fingertips. “Already two steps ahead of you!” I hollered back.

“Good.” Avery turned to the others, rain plastering his hair to his forehead. “Open fire!” he shouted.

At the same moment, the thing charged as Cameron, Dallas, Jason, and Avery opened fire, bullets tearing into it.

That many bullets—that much lead—being dumped into it should have dropped it. Instead, it only barely slowed, its momentum carrying it forward through the storm of gunfire.

“Hamish, now!” Avery hollered.

I released the spell.

One after another, three manabolts slammed into the thing’s chest. It howled in anger, sending some stumbling back hands clamped against ears, but I could already see something else happening beneath

the noise.

The amount of mana suddenly flooding its body reacted violently with all the technology threaded through it, and the result wasn't pretty. Energy cascaded out of control. Everything overloaded at once—sections fried, sparks erupting as circuits short-circuited in rapid succession.

Then the creature exploded.

Cameron and Dallas were close enough that they flinched back as black goo splattered the outside of Milyah's shield.

We stared at it, half expecting it to reform from the puddle of goop it had left behind. But it didn't. The rain washed over the scorched ground, thinning the oily residue until there was nothing left but smoke and the faint residue of mana.

"Is it actually dead?" Milyah asked as she finally lowered the shield spell. Her hands were trembling now that she wasn't holding it together by force alone, the adrenaline bleeding out of her all at once. Dallas stepped up and wrapped an arm around her waist just before her legs gave out completely, keeping her upright as she sagged against him.

"Seems like it," Avery said, scanning the area anyway.

"Good riddance," Jason spat. "Fucker better stay down."

Cameron let out a long, exhausted sigh and tucked his gun away, shoulders slumping now that the fight was over. "Well, that's going to be one hell of a report to give the client."

I flexed my fingers, the last traces of mana still buzzing under my skin. "Jason?" I asked. He shifted beside me and hissed through his teeth, rolling his shoulder.

"Armor didn't love that," he said.

"Yeah?" I asked.

"If I ever said I didn't need an upgrade," he went on, "feel free to remind me I was wrong." He gave his chest piece a light knock. "Whatever that thing did, Genesis felt it. Hard."

Cameron had drifted a few steps ahead of the rest of us, angling toward the far side of the street, when something snapped through the rain.

The sound came a fraction of a second before the impact.

Cameron jerked as it struck him high in the shoulder, the force spinning him halfway around. He went

down hard, skidding across the ground.

Before any of us could shout, the paper burned.

I felt it the instant the protection spell triggered—a sharp tug at the back of my mind, like a cord being yanked tight. The sigil I'd given Cameron earlier flared into existence, translucent and brilliant, just as something dark and fast splashed against it.

The ward held long enough to deflect it.

Whatever had hit him sloughed off in a wet smear, splattering across the ground in thick black streaks. The bullet, if that's what it had been, had burst apart on contact, its casing dissolving as the sludge inside hissed against the ward before spilling across the ground.

"Cameron!" Milyah shouted.

We all were already moving as Cameron pushed himself upright. I dropped to one knee beside him avoiding the sludge as I did.

"Cameron you good?" I asked.

"Well, I've had worse." He said wryly. "Remember, Avery shot me when we first met."

I helped him back to his feet. "Jason, did Genesis track where that came from?"

Jason shook his head. "Not exactly. Like I said, Genesis is barely hanging on as is." He paused, "'I take that back.'" He threw out a warning hand. "Everyone get ready — I'm picking up multiple heat signatures."

He frowned at nothing, eyes flicking as if tracking something only he could see. "They're... uneven."

I looked past Cameron, in the direction Jason was facing.

There was a figure silhouetted in a doorway. It hadn't been there a moment ago. Or maybe it had, and I just hadn't registered it.

Avery had seen it too. "What the frag-?"

Jason took a step closer to Cameron and me, his head tilted slightly, like he was trying to reconcile what his eyes were telling him with what Genesis was feeding him.

"How many?" Dallas demanded.

"Five. No—wait. Ten?" Jason said, trying to keep up, but I guess Genesis was updating his HUD faster

than he could get the words out. “They’re not holding still. It keeps—”

He stopped talking.

Across the street, another figure stood at the edge of the square. Then one farther down the road.

“Jason,” Avery said carefully. “How many now?”

Jason swallowed. “I don’t know.”

That did it.

Because Jason always knew.

I turned slowly, forcing myself to actually look this time — not at one doorway, not at one street, but at the whole space around us. Doorways. Corners. Gaps between buildings. The open ground we’d crossed without thinking twice minutes ago.

“Fuck.”

Vesper

After Morrow left, I excused myself from the hospital, ignoring the doctor's thinly veiled objections. He tried to protest—something about observation, about liability—but I was already pulling my jacket on, already halfway out the door. I needed distance. From the room. From the lights. From anyone who thought they had a say in what happened to my body.

I didn't stop moving until I was a few blocks away.

The public restroom was half-hidden beneath a transit overpass, concrete walls tagged with old graffiti and newer warnings. I slipped inside and locked the door behind me, the sound of the bolt sliding home louder than it should've been in the cramped space.

The air smelled faintly of disinfectant and rust. Fluorescent lights flickered overhead, one of them buzzing like it was on its last legs. I leaned forward, bracing my hands against the sink, and stared down at the metal as if it might steady me.

The bathroom was quiet except for the drip of the broken faucet—slow, irregular. Each drop hit the basin like an hourglass, counting down to something.

My reflection wavered in the broken mirror, fractured into uneven shards that never quite lined up no matter how still I stood.

I could make my problem go away.

The thought slid in easily. Too easily. It settled into place like it had been waiting for an invitation.

The debt would still be there, sure—numbers don't vanish just because blood gets spilled—but the pressure would. The constant tightening in my chest. The feeling of being watched, weighed, measured for usefulness. No one would miss a loan shark. Not really. People might pretend to, might light candles and shake their heads, but the world would be cleaner without him in it.

I'd taken lives before for money.

That truth didn't even sting anymore. It sat there, flat and dull, like an old scar you stop noticing until someone points it out. How would this be any different? How many lives had he already ruined—bled dry, cornered, broken down to desperation? Mine wasn't special. I was just the one finally thinking about pushing back.

My fingers tightened. The sink groaned again, protesting quietly.

My gaze flickered up to the mirror.

Green eyes stared back at me—or pieces of them did, caught between cracks and missing slivers of glass. For a moment they didn't look like mine at all. The color was too bright, too sharp, like something powered instead of alive. There was a faint glow behind them, an illusion of light where there shouldn't have been any.

More machine than me.

The thought made my stomach twist. I leaned closer, studying the reflection like it might confess something if I stared hard enough. I blinked. The glow didn't go away. If anything, it seemed to sharpen, pupils adjusting too quickly, too precisely.

Was this me thinking?

Or was it Ghost, nudging probabilities around, smoothing the path toward the most efficient solution?

I swallowed and forced my grip to loosen, metal groaning in relief as my fingers finally let go. My hands were shaking now—not fear exactly, but something adjacent to it. A tremor born from the realization that the line I was staring at wasn't new.

I'd crossed it before.

And it had been easier every time.

I straightened slowly, backing away from the sink as if it might accuse me. I turned and fled from my own reflection and what I was slowly becoming.

Vesper

Buildings smeared into bands of light in my peripheral vision as I ran, neon lights bleeding together in the rain-slicked glass and metal of the inner city.

Gradually, the glow thinned. The polished towers gave way to sagging brick and rusted fire escapes as I crossed into the Old District. Neon reflections faded into dim sodium streetlamps and darkened windows.

At some point, I'd taken the vertical route. A maintenance ladder, a half-collapsed balcony, then the rooftops. My boots scattering puddles as I vaulted over ancient generators and dented air-conditioning units that rattled in protest, satellite dishes leaned at drunken angles and loose cables snapped in the wind like tripwires.

I didn't pay much attention to any of it. My focus was fixed on one thing—putting as much distance as possible between me and that restroom. Between me and my accusing reflection.

I only slowed because my HUD and Ghost wouldn't shut up.

Warnings burst across my vision in vibrant red. Ghost reminding me I was still technically “recovering” from yesterday.

“Yeah, yeah.” I muttered. Hard to forget fighting living bunkers.

I vaulted a gap anyway.

The landing jarred something loose in my side. A hot, splintering pain shot through my ribs and wrapped tight around my lungs. My breath snagged halfway in, like my body was reconsidering the whole oxygen thing. Because apparently oxygen is optional.

I finally dropped onto a support beam seventy stories above the street, the metal groaning softly under my weight, and dismissed the warning notifications with an annoyed huff.

Below me, New Seattle's Old District sprawled in half-finished silhouettes. Skeletal towers ribbed with scaffolding, cranes frozen mid-swing like mechanical herons, entire city blocks caged in framework and plastic sheeting. Floodlights washed everything in harsh white, carving sharp angles and long shadows. The night shift was in full swing: the grind of drills, the rhythmic clang of metal on metal, the distant hydraulic sigh of heavy machinery cycling through another endless task.

Untainted by smog and ozone the air up here tasted cleaner, sharper, like the wind hadn't decided which decade it belonged to.

I inhaled again, slower this time, and caught a faint hint of seawater drifting in from the Sound. It swept

through me, chasing out the last stubborn memory of my reflection. Gods that felt better.

I tilted my head back, letting the wind press against my throat. A stray strand of hair slipped free and into my eyes. I swept it away without thinking, only for it to whip right back across my mouth, tasting faintly of salt and copper. I didn't bother fixing it again. Let the wind win.

For a moment, I just sat there. Legs dangling over open air, suspended above seventy stories of nothing. The beam was barely wider than my foot, one wrong shift of weight—one careless lean, and I'd tip forward into a very long fall.

It didn't stop me from leaning a little further forward.

I stayed there for several more minutes, letting the semi-silence settle around me. Up here, away from everything, New Seattle gave the illusion of being almost normal - or what it could have been during the Before. Distant almost gentle. I shook that thought away with a slight laugh. New Seattle was anything but gentle. Still, the longer I stayed, the more the illusion softened, and my mind began to spiral, drifting toward darker paths I usually kept locked away.

Yeah. Time to head down.

My hands still felt like they belonged to someone else.

A couple of drinks wouldn't fix the past two days — wouldn't fix Ghost — but they might quiet the tremor long enough to think.

I needed it out of my head. Out of my spine. Out of whatever part of me it had decided was negotiable.

I knew a place that'd do it cheap. A place that wouldn't shove me deeper into debt for the privilege of owning my own body.

I stood on the beam, arms out for balance, the wind worrying at me like it was testing how badly I wanted to live. A faint whine ran through my legs as the servo-stabilizers compensated, locking my stance before I could sway.

For a moment, the city loosened its grip on me.

Sunlight scattered across the water in broken shards. The docks stretched out in long, uneven lines, planks bleached pale and warm under bare feet.

My brothers were already ahead of me, shouting over the slap of waves against the pylons.

“You're slow, Vesper!”

“Last one across buys dinner!”

I ran.

Wood thudded under my heels. The gap yawned. I jumped.

For a heartbeat, I was weightless.

Then the next pier caught me, jolting up through my knees. Someone whooped. Someone else splashed into the water with a curse that dissolved into laughter. The sound bounced off the pilings and came back bigger, brighter, like the whole harbor was laughing with us.

I remember thinking we would always have this.

Then the wind tore it away.

A seagull screamed overhead.

I blinked, and the docks were gone.

My fingers pressed against my temple, as if I could hold the memory there a little longer. Tears gathered at the corners of my eyes. I scrubbed them away before they could fall. I hadn’t wanted to lose those days. Them. But fate loves playing jokes and some days it felt like it had its entire focus on me.

I forced the memory down and moved.

Stillness was dangerous. Give my thoughts an inch and they’d drag me somewhere I couldn’t afford to go.

The skeletal frame of the building loomed ahead, a jagged silhouette of exposed girders and half-finished floors gnawed hollow by time and neglect. Wind threaded through the empty structure, turning it into a vast, mournful instrument that groaned and whistled with every gust. Panels hung loose like torn skin. Rebar jutted out in rusted clusters.

I grabbed the first vertical support and swung down.

The motion pulled hard across my side.

Pain flared. Sharp, hot, and immediate. Like someone had driven a wedge between my ribs and twisted. My breath hitched mid-draw, lungs stuttering in protest. For a split second my grip faltered, fingers tightening a fraction too late around the cold steel. I swallowed the sound that tried to climb up my throat and forced my boots to find the narrow lip below.

My armor compensated before I consciously could. Micro-servos along my spine tightened,

redistributing weight through my hips and thighs. The stabilizers in my knee joints whispered to life, correcting the slight forward pitch my injury had caused. A subtle counter force nudged me back over my center of gravity—gentle, insistent, like a hand at the small of my back.

Then it over corrected.

The shift was tiny, barely perceptible, but enough to make my balance feel artificial, avoiding a stumble by pushing me half a degree too far the other direction. My ankle rolled against the edge of the beam, and I had to fight the suit's assistance to settle into something that felt like my own equilibrium instead of a machine's interpretation of it.

Another drop. Another landing.

Each impact sent a dull shock up through my legs and straight into my ribcage, where it bloomed into a deeper, more insidious ache. The metal rang under my weight, the sound hollow and accusing, vibrations humming through bone and bruised cartilage. My side tightened with every movement, a band of pressure cinching my lungs, making each breath feel rationed—like my body was metering out oxygen on a strict budget.

The gaps between levels yawned open beneath me, dark and patient. I could feel the pull of them now, not as an abstract risk but as a very real consequence of one misstep, one moment where pain overruled precision. Sweat slicked my palms inside my gloves despite the cold wind, and I adjusted my grip before releasing again.

Drop. Catch. Land.

A sharp inhale betrayed me on the next impact, the breath sawing in and out of my chest. White sparks flickered at the edges of my vision, not from height but from the strain of pretending I wasn't injured.

I finally reached street level.

The last drop was the worst. My arms trembled from the accumulated strain, my grip strength eroded by pain and overuse, and when my boots hit cracked pavement the impact punched straight through Ghost's dampeners and into my ribs. A white-hot spike of pain flared along my side, stealing the air from my lungs in a silent, open-mouthed gasp. For a moment I just stood there, hunched slightly forward, one hand braced against the cold steel column behind me as the world narrowed to the tight band around my chest.

Reminders erupted across my HUD.

Translucent panes stacked themselves in the corner of my vision—vital warnings in clinical red, posture corrections in sterile blue, a persistent amber banner politely informing me that I was still recovering.

Ghost threaded through it all, tagging data points, flagging anomalies, offering helpful projections about how continued strain could convert “recovering” into “critical” in under twelve minutes.

I dismissed the first wave with a sharp flick of my fingers. The notifications shattered into translucent fragments and dissolved, only to reform in slightly smaller font, as if compromise might make them more bearable.

“Not now,” I muttered.

A biometric graph expanded anyway, lines jagged and accusing. Oxygen saturation dipping. Cortisol spiking. Microfracture probability recalculating in real time. Ghost tightened the armor another incremental degree around my torso, attempting to stabilize what it clearly did not trust me to manage on my own.

I swiped again—harder this time. The warnings blinked out completely, leaving only the faint ambient glow of the HUD’s baseline interface.

I pushed off the column, ignoring the slow, treacherous wave of nausea that curled up the back of my throat. It rose hot and metallic, a delayed echo of adrenaline and impact, threatening to fold me in half right there on the sidewalk. I swallowed hard and kept moving.

The first few steps felt disconnected, like my boots belonged to someone else and I was merely issuing delayed commands. The armor compensated instantly—micro-adjustments at my hips to counter the slight sway, subtle resistance in my right knee where my stride faltered. It tried to smooth me out, iron me flat into something steady and presentable. The assistance was so seamless most people wouldn’t notice.

I noticed.

Each correction felt like a quiet hand steering me, nudging my posture upright when my body wanted to curl inward. The suit’s stabilization algorithms hummed at the edge of perception, tracking my center of gravity, predicting missteps before I made them. Mildly irritating.

My path carried me deeper into the Old District, past darkened storefronts and rusted security grates tagged with layers of old graffiti. Somewhere above, a loose sign creaked in the wind, the sound arrhythmic and hollow.

Anytime Ghost tried to offer any sort of feedback, I instantly dismissed it. The alerts barely had time to fully render before I cut them off—red flickers at the edge of my vision, half-formed graphs, the ghost of a warning tone strangled into silence. I didn’t read them. I didn’t want to know. It was probably paranoia, but I could still feel my bones crack under the strain Ghost had put me through.

Eventually, I found the street I was looking for. My body remembered even though it had been three years since I was last here. I slowed just before I reached the building. No one could miss it.

The building itself was unremarkable, virtually indistinguishable from any other building on this street, with its weathered and crumbling brick facade.

As I got closer, Ghost lit up my HUD again politely pointing out that my heart rate had spiked significantly. “No shit, Sherlock.” I muttered as I dismissed the notification.

I glanced around. The area was mostly empty, the usual street noise reduced to a distant hum of traffic and the occasional rattle of loose metal somewhere overhead. A couple of pedestrians approached from the corner, saw where I was standing, and quickly crossed to the other side of the street, their pace just a little too brisk to be casual. One of them kept looking back until they disappeared around a parked delivery van. They gave the building a wide berth.

I couldn’t blame them. Only desperate people came here willingly. Even then, they exhausted all other options first—friends, favors, prayer, denial.

Suppose that made me both a fool and desperate.

A flicker of motion drew my attention upward. One of the security cameras, yellowed with age, whirred softly as it turned in my direction, its lens adjusting with a faint mechanical click. Another followed, then a third, their movements staggered, like predators coordinating without urgency. A small red diode blinked to life beneath the nearest unit.

I approached the door and raised a hand to knock, but before my fist could even make contact, a small view port snapped open with a metallic clack. The sudden movement made me flinch despite myself. A pair of eyes appeared in the narrow slot—bloodshot, suspicious, set deep in a face I could barely make out behind the reinforced glass. The skin around them was sallow and pitted, mapped with old needle tracks and the faint geometric scarring of removed interface ports. One iris jittered a fraction too slow to be natural, the telltale lag of a budget optic struggling to auto focus.

“We are not accepting new customers at this time,” the man said, his voice flattened by a cheap speaker grille. It carried the bored finality of someone who’d repeated the line a thousand times and meant it every time.

“I’m not a new customer,” I replied, unable to keep the edge out of my voice, doing my best to avoid catching my reflection in the glass. “Is Fahren still in charge of this dump?”

The man’s gaze narrowed, I heard his eye try to focus again, the faint mechanical whirr stuttering like a dying insect caught in his skull. “Don’t recognize you. Who’s askin’?”

Before I got a chance to respond, another voice drifted through the narrow crack in the door.

“Wells, who is it?”

Even muffled by the reinforced steel and whatever cheap audio filters they’d wired into the place, I’d know that voice anywhere. Three years wasn’t long enough to forget it.

Wells scratched at his jaw, chrome fingers clicking softly against stubble. He leaned back and glanced over his shoulder.

“Dunno,” the man rasped. “Some chick claiming to know you.”

For a moment I wondered if he’d tell Wells to send me away.

Then the locks disengaged.

One by one.

Heavy magnetic bolts clunked aside with mechanical precision, followed by the hydraulic hiss of the door sliding open the rest of the way. Harsh neon light spilled into the hallway, painting everything in sickly blues and purples.

And there he was.

Fahrren leaned casually against the inner frame like he had nothing to fear, and knowing him and what he did for a living meant he probably didn’t.

His long coat was threaded with faint circuitry that pulsed softly under the fabric, tiny veins of light crawling along the seams. One of his eyes glowed faint amber, the cybernetic lens adjusting as it focused on me.

A slow grin spread across his face.

“Well,” he said, voice dripping with recognition, “if it isn’t the little butterfly.”

His gaze flicked over me, quick and sharp, cataloging everything.

The grin widened.

“Come in.”

Wells stepped aside reluctantly, fingers tapping against the doorframe as I passed.

Hamish

They had us surrounded.

Milyah winced, pushed off Dallas, and took a shaky step forward. Her hands spread, fingers trembling as she tried to pull the shield back into place.

But just from looking at her I could see it wasn't coming easy. Her breathing was wrong, just too fast, too shallow and there was a gray, hollow look under her eyes. The first shield had taken more out of her than she'd admit, especially without any mana booster to lean on.

I stepped away from Cameron and set a hand on her shoulder. "Let me take this one."

The tension bled out of her fingers. Whatever she'd been holding onto unraveled, the air in front of her settling back into rain and gun smoke. She gave me a look, relief edged with embarrassment, before Jason pulled her a few steps back and pressed a recovery potion vial into her palm.

"What's the plan, boss?" I asked Avery, forcing the words past the dryness in my throat.

Avery didn't look at me right away. His gaze tracked the shifting silhouettes in the downpour—doorways filling, empty streets no longer empty.

"We need to clear a path through them," he said at last. "If we do, we book it for the vehicle and get the fuck out of Dodge."

Shapes moved at the edges of visibility—wrong angles, staggered gaits, limbs that didn't agree with the bodies they were attached to.

Something screamed.

Not the bone-rattling shriek from before—this was lower, layered, wet. Multiple throats trying to make one sound.

They charged.

No coordination. No tactics. Just raw, suicidal momentum.

I stepped forward and slammed my will into the space in front of us.

Mana surged out of me in a violent rush, coalescing into a curved barrier that snapped into place with a sound like glass flexing under pressure.

The first creature hit it a heartbeat later.

The impact traveled through the shield and into my bones like a struck bell. My teeth clacked together. Light bent around the point of contact as if reality itself had dented.

Then another hit.

And another.

They threw themselves at it with mindless fury—metal limbs sparking, cables whipping, black slurry spraying across the barrier in oily fans that hissed where mana burned it away.

“Hold!” Avery barked behind me.

Easy for him to say.

Each strike was a hammer blow against my concentration. The shield wasn’t a wall—it was an argument with physics, and physics was pushing back hard.

Sweat beaded on my brow despite the cold rain. My hands trembled, fingers curling as if I were physically bracing the barrier. Mana drained in a steady, merciless stream, the sensation like blood leaving an open wound.

One of the things slammed into the shield headfirst. Its skull split along a seam, peeling back to reveal a nest of wiring and pulsing gel. Electricity arced across the barrier, spider webbing in brilliant blue fractures that made my vision strobe.

The lattice flickered.

“Hamish!” Cameron’s voice cut through the roar somewhere to my left “It’s destabilizing!”

“I know!” I said through gritted teeth.

Jason and Dallas stepped forward and opened fire. Muzzle flashes strobed through the rain, casting the attackers in freeze-frame glimpses: too many joints, too many teeth, too much metal fused into meat.

A body hit the shield and stuck there, twitching. Its elongated arms scrabbled against the barrier, fingers splitting open into hooked prongs that screeched as they dragged across the surface.

I flinched.

The lapse was only a heartbeat, a single stutter in my focus, but it was enough. The shield rippled outward in a visible distortion, its surface dimming as the lattice of force destabilized. A spiderweb of pale blue fractures raced across it, sealing and reopening as another impact slammed into the weakening arc.

Pain lanced behind my eyes. My breath hitched.

I clenched my jaw and shoved more mana into the spell, forcing the geometry to lock back into place. The barrier brightened, lines sharpening as the cracks fused shut, but the effort sent a hot spike of exhaustion down my spine. My hands trembled where they hovered in front of me.

“Hamish,” Milyah said, her voice close—closer than I expected. “Let me take a turn.”

For a fraction of a second, I tore my gaze from the writhing shapes beyond the barrier and looked at her. Rain plastered dark strands of hair to her face, water streaming off the edge of her hood. Her hands were already raised, mana coiling faintly around her fingers in tight, controlled spirals.

“I’m okay for now,” she said, softer this time, like she could see straight through the lie I was about to tell myself.

Milyah nodded, and her mana surged forward. I felt it more than saw it as she shaped a barrier just behind mine. The air there thickened, light bending in a faint shimmer that overlapped the edges of my failing shield.

Once I was sure hers was stable, I finally released my spell.

The moment the mana left me, my knees threatened to give out. The sudden absence felt like stepping off a ledge into an abyss. The world tilted, my vision tunneling as exhaustion slammed into me all at once.

It made me stagger.

Avery caught my arm before I could hit the ground, his grip firm as he steadied me on my feet. “Easy,” he muttered, keeping one hand locked on my sleeve as another impact thudded against Milyah’s barrier.

I grabbed another recovery potion, one I had stuck into a pocket for easier access, popped the cork with my teeth and tossed it back.

“How much ammo we got left?” I asked after swallowing.

Cameron dropped onto one knee beside a low chunk of broken masonry, swapping . The empty one clattered against the stone before he shoved a fresh clip into place and racked the weapon. “Eh,” he said, not looking up, “I got two left after this.”

Jason and Dallas checked theirs almost in unison.

“Same,” Jason said. His armor lights flickered faintly as Genesis struggled to keep up. “Maybe a mag and a half if I’m careful.”

“I have a really dumb idea,” I said.

Avery glanced over at me. “Probably better than what any of us got.”

I nodded slowly, “Okay. Milyah and I will use the shields we can conjure and basically drive a wedge through the center. Keep a gap between both just big enough for us to get through.”

“Do that and we make a beeline for the van,” Dallas finished for me, catching on quick.

“Exactly.”

“I’m all for it,” Avery said with a short shrug, like we were discussing routes on a map instead of betting our lives on a sprint. He tightened his grip on his rifle and glanced toward the street where we’d left the vehicle. “We’ll see if a van can outrun these bastards.”

“On your mark, Hamish.”

Avery said as he fired a couple more rounds into a creature’s knees. The shots cracked sharp through the rain, and the thing jerked mid-stride, its legs folding awkwardly beneath it. It hit the pavement hard and had to claw its way forward, dragging itself through the water and black slurry.

I swallowed against a sudden wave of nausea as I pulled mana up from the hollow place inside my chest. It felt thin. Frayed. Like trying to draw water from a well that had already run dry once tonight.

I forced it anyway.

A shield snapped into place in front of me with a dull, concussive thrum that rattled my teeth. The air warped, bending the rain around its curved surface.

“Now!”

Milyah shifted instantly, sliding her barrier sideways. The two shields angled apart just enough to form a narrow corridor between them, a wedge pointed straight at the thinnest part of the mob.

“Go!” Avery barked.

Dallas, Jason, and Cameron didn’t hesitate. They bolted through the gap, boots splashing through puddles. Gunfire flared from inside the corridor as they fired outward, keeping the creatures from collapsing in on us.

Something slammed into my shield from the left. The impact reverberated down my arms, nearly knocking my footing loose.

I thrust my arms out wider, straining to hold the arc steady, and threw a second barrier up behind Milyah's. The added strain made my vision swim, black creeping in at the edges.

"Run!" I shouted at her.

For a split second, she hesitated. I could see it in the tightness of her shoulders, the way her head half-turned like she meant to argue.

Then she ran.

She slipped through the opening toward the others, her shield dissolving the moment she cleared the wedge.

The pressure on mine doubled immediately.

"C'mon, dumbass!" Avery snapped from my left, grabbing my jacket and dragging me along. "No one's playing hero!"

Another body hurled itself at the barrier. Cracks of light spidered across its surface.

I staggered forward, forcing my legs to move, dragging the wedge with me one step at a time as the creatures swarmed along its edges, clawing and shrieking in the rain.

Vesper

“Well, if it isn’t the little Butterfly come crawling back after the Hawk stole her away and promised her the world. How’s that going for you?” Fahrren said by way of greeting. “Can’t imagine it’s going well if you’re back here.”

His voice carried the same silken mockery I remembered.

Gods, I wanted to bitch-slap that condescending smirk off his face.

The overhead lights caught the chrome at his collar and the faint seam along his jaw where real met reinforced, making his grin look almost bolted on.

“What’s it been? Two years?”

“Three,” I corrected.

“Has it been that long?” Fahren mused as he circled me, the soft whirr of concealed servos betraying how much of him no longer relied on real muscle. “I see you’ve upgraded since the last time I saw you,” he added without waiting for my response. “Did the Hawk buy that for you?”

He gestured lazily toward my armor.

“No,” I said shortly. “But it’s the reason I’m here.”

Fahren’s eyebrow lifted slightly, interest flickering behind that artificial eye.

“Oh?” he said.

I nodded, keeping my gaze from drifting around the room. I didn’t need to look to remember the surgical tables, the bins of stripped cyberware, and the steady stream of bodies that passed through this place—some leaving with upgrades, others leaving lighter than they arrived.

“So what’s wrong with your pretty little armor?” Fahrren asked.

He stepped closer before I could answer, his gaze already crawling over the plating like a mechanic inspecting a familiar machine. His fingers flicked the curve of my shoulder.

I slapped his hand away.

“Nothing’s wrong, per se,” I said.

Fahren mouth twitched. One eyebrow lifted slowly, disbelief written plainly across his face.

“Nothing’s wrong,” he repeated. “Yet here you are, standing in my shop after three years, asking for my help.”

“I need the combat AI removed,” I said.

For the first time since I’d walked in, he actually looked surprised.

“Remove the AI?” he said slowly.

He circled me again, slower this time, eyes scanning the seams of my armor. I heard the faint whir of the servos in his legs as he moved.

“That looks like a Ghost model,” he continued, tapping lightly against the plating along my side. “Military grade adaptive interface. Combat predictive processing. Probably cost more than this entire block.”

He leaned slightly closer, studying the armor like it might confess something if he stared hard enough.

“Why on earth would you want to remove its AI?”

“I don’t need it,” I said. The lie came easily. Too easily. “My personal HUD and AI are enough.”

“Right...” He clearly didn’t believe me. But I wasn’t about to tell him the real reason.

An AI that hijacked the user’s body would be the perfect reason for him to keep me trapped on one of his surgical tables while he poked around my head out of pure curiosity.

“I don’t care if you believe me or not,” I snapped. “I’m paying you to get rid of it.”

“Hmm.” Fahrren tapped a finger thoughtfully against the plating of my armor, the metal ringing softly under the contact. “Well, it’s very dangerous to separate the armor from the AI that runs it.”

“Dangerous and risky are your currency,” I retorted.

Fahrren scratched at his chin thoughtfully, “I could try swapping your AI out with a different one,” he mused after a moment.

“Great,” I said quickly. “Let’s get going.”

He grinned again.

Shit.

I’d let my desperation show.

“And don’t you dare think about using Raze. I’ll tough it out without it.” I said as an afterthought. Trying to run damage control.

Fahrren grin widened slightly at that.

Damn it. Raze was too addictive. I’d been there once before, riding that razor-edge clarity it gave you, and after I finally got clean I swore to myself I’d never touch it again.

“Too bad about that,” he laughed. “I remember that’s what made me give you that nickname.”

He leaned in close, invading my space the way predators do when they know their prey can’t run. “You were so pretty on all fours, licking it up off the floor.”

Unpleasant memories flooded back.

I could see it like it was happening all over again.

The same room—though it had looked even harsher back then. The lights too bright, the metal tables reflecting everything in ugly, unforgiving angles. I’d been younger, thinner, my nerves fried from withdrawal and desperation.

Fahren and a handful of his cronies had formed a loose circle around me, their laughter bouncing off the concrete walls.

One of them shoved me.

Hard.

My knees hit the floor first, the impact jolting up through my legs. My palms slapped against the cold concrete a heartbeat later, skin scraping rough against the grit and oil ground into the surface.

The vial had shattered when it fell.

Raze spread across the floor in a thin, glittering puddle, the floral and chemical scent of it sharp enough to sting my nose. Even diluted by the dust and grime, I could almost taste it in the air.

Back then, that scent had felt like salvation.

“Go on,” Fahrren had said, crouching just enough so his shadow fell over me. “If you need it that bad...”

His voice had been soft. Amused.

Cruel.

“Lick it up.”

The room had erupted with laughter.

“Fuck you,” I growled, snapping back to the present and shoving him back a step. “Don’t you dare bring that up.”

Fahrren chuckled softly and held up his hands in a mock defensive gesture, palms out as if he expected me to swing. The sound of his laughter echoed unpleasantly in my ears, too close to the cruel laughter that still lived in the back of my memory.

“Easy, Butterfly,” he said, amusement curling in his voice. “Still as fiery as ever.”

For a brief, dangerous moment, I imagined closing the distance between us. My hands locking around his throat. The sharp twist it would take to snap his neck now that my armor amplified every movement.

It would be easy.

Too easy.

Even though I knew it had to be Ghost in my subconscious the thought was very tempting.

But I forced the image away. As much as I hated him, as much as every instinct in my body screamed to wipe that grin off his face permanently, I needed him right now.

And he knew it.

“Just do what I’m paying you for,” I snapped.

“Alright, chill,” he said, turning toward the back rooms where the operations usually took place. “C’mon. I’m sure I don’t have to remind you which way to go.”

I followed him, keeping a bit of distance between us as we walked down the narrow hall. I knew things were different now. I had my own gear, my own credits, and more than enough strength to tell him exactly where he could shove his attitude.

Still, walking these halls again brought back old memories.

No matter how much had changed, I couldn’t quite shake the feeling that he still had some kind of control over me here.

Hamish

My desperate plan had sort of paid off, but both Milyah and I had burned through a huge chunk of mana getting there, and I'd already been frayed before we even started. The moment we finally stopped moving and formed a defensive position, the strain caught up with me.

I doubled over, retching hard.

Nothing came up except bile and the bitter aftertaste of potion residue, but my stomach kept trying anyway. My head throbbed like someone had driven a spike through my skull, and every nerve in my body felt raw. Magic always took a toll on non-magical beings, but tonight it felt like it had decided to collect interest.

Gods, I wished I were an elf some days. They handled this sort of thing far better than baseline humans ever could.

I wiped my mouth with the back of my hand and forced myself upright again. Around us, the team had formed a rough perimeter, guns up, eyes scanning the dark gaps between buildings. The rain hadn't let up. If anything, it had gotten heavier, hammering the street and turning the ground into slick, reflective black.

"We can't keep this up," Milyah said.

Her voice wasn't panicked, just tired. I glanced over at her and saw the same exhaustion I felt written across her face. Maintaining barriers this long was brutal, even for someone who actually specialized in defensive magic.

She was right.

Sooner or later we'd burn through the rest of our mana reserves... and after that we'd run out of recovery potions.

Then we'd be out of options.

"How much farther to the van?" Jason asked.

"Half a mile, maybe more," Avery replied. "Why?"

Jason blinked rain out of his eyes and looked back toward the direction we'd come from.

"I could hold them off while you all make a break for it," he said.

The words landed like a brick.

“Not happening,” Avery said immediately. His tone left absolutely no room for argument. “No one gets to play hero today.”

Jason’s jaw tightened. “Then figure something else out,” he snapped. “Because the way I see it, one of us has to be that person so everyone else survives.”

Avery swore under his breath. “Look, I know we signed up for risks every time we take a job,” he said, rain running down the side of his face as he scanned the dark streets around us. “But it’s my responsibility to make sure we all make it back.”

I could tell Jason wasn’t really listening. Not completely.

His eyes were fixed somewhere past Avery’s shoulder, watching the shapes moving at the far end of the street.

“Hamish and Milyah can’t keep this up,” Jason said.

No one answered.

The others stayed quiet, shifting uneasily, unsure what to say. We all knew Jason was right, but none of us wanted to be the one to say it out loud. No one wanted to be the one who decided that Jason should be left behind with those things.

Jason made the decision for us.

He reached down, pulled a grenade from his bag, and popped the pin before anyone could stop him.

“Jason—” Avery started.

But he was already moving. Twenty five feet away and the distance only grew.

He bolted straight for the swarm, boots splashing through the rain-soaked street as the creatures began to turn toward him. A second later he hurled the grenade into their midst just as another one body slammed into him from the side.

For a moment we all froze.

Then Avery recovered first.

“Shit!” he swore again, snapping his rifle back up. “Let’s go, people!”

That got us all moving—everyone except Milyah.

She stood frozen for a moment, staring back down the rain-slick street toward where Jason had

disappeared into the swarm. The downpour blurred the distance, turning everything into shifting shadows and flashes of movement, but we all knew what waited back there.

“I could go help him,” she whispered.

Her voice was small, barely audible over the pounding rain and distant gunfire, but the desperation in it cut straight through the noise.

Cameron reached her first. He grabbed her arm and started pulling her along as we ran.

“No,” he said firmly. “He wouldn’t want that.”

“You don’t know that!” she shot back, twisting against his grip. Her voice cracked halfway through the words, the strain finally breaking through the composure she’d held together all night.

Tears mixed with the rain on her face as she tried to turn back toward the street behind us.

Dallas grabbed her other arm without slowing down.

“Move,” he said, breath already coming hard as we sprinted down the dark road.

Between the two of them they dragged her forward, half-running, half-stumbling as the rest of us pushed ahead toward the van.

The van finally came into view through the rain.

Its dark shape sat crooked along the side of the road exactly where we’d left it, half-hidden behind a broken streetlight that flickered weakly against the downpour. For a moment the sight of it sent a surge of relief through me so strong my knees almost buckled.

We were close.

Too bad Jason’s sacrifice hadn’t bought us enough time.

Several of the creatures had broken off from the main swarm.

They were chasing us.

Their silhouettes burst from the darkness between buildings and alleyways, long limbs pumping as they sprinted down the flooded street. The rain distorted them, turning their outlines into shifting shadows, but every few seconds lightning flashed somewhere far off and revealed them in awful detail—skin torn open to reveal cables and metal beneath, limbs bending at wrong angles as if pain simply didn’t exist for them.

“Milyah, move!” Avery shouted.

She tried.

Her boot slid on the slick pavement and she pitched forward with a startled cry. For a heartbeat it looked like she was going to faceplant straight into the road.

Dallas caught her under one arm while Cameron grabbed the other, hauling her upright before she could go down.

“Keep running!” Cameron barked, half-dragging her as they sprinted.

Something exploded out of the rain behind them.

A creature lunged low and fast, its ruined jaws snapping shut with a loud, wet crack exactly where Milyah’s head had been a second earlier.

“Fuck!” Dallas swore.

He didn’t even slow down.

Still running, he twisted his body and drove a brutal kick into the side of the thing’s skull. The impact landed with a dull, meaty thud that sent it staggering sideways.

There was a sickening tearing sound.

The creature’s lower jaw ripped completely free and went flying across the pavement, skidding through a puddle of rainwater and black sludge.

The thing barely reacted.

Black fluid poured from the shredded ruin of its mouth as it clawed back toward us, fingers digging into the pavement as it tried to lunge again.

My stomach lurched.

How had they gotten so close?

I risked a glance over my shoulder and immediately wished I hadn’t.

Shapes were pouring out of the darkness behind us. Not just one or two—dozens of them, spreading across the street, climbing over abandoned cars and scrambling across broken sidewalks as they chased us down.

Some ran on two legs.

Others dropped to all fours, moving with a horrifying, spider-like speed that made my skin crawl.

Lightning flashed again.

For a split second the whole street lit up white.

And in that moment I saw just how many of them there were.

“Hamish!” Avery shouted from ahead. “Eyes forward!”

I tore my gaze away and forced my legs to keep moving, lungs burning as the van grew closer through the storm.

Avery and I reached the van at almost the exact same time, the others only a few steps behind. Avery’s fingers had just brushed the handle when a large shadow passed overhead as Cameron yelled behind us.

“Look out!”

Metal shrieked as something slammed down on top of the van hard enough to make the entire vehicle shudder. Glass shattered in a violent spray as the roof crumpled inward beneath the creature’s weight, the windshield spiderwebbing instantly before collapsing in a cascade of jagged shards.

“Motherfucker!” Avery swore.

He stumbled backward just in time as shards of safety glass rained down where his face had been a heartbeat earlier. The creature shifted, its weight grinding the ruined roof deeper with a screech of tortured metal.

Another creature came lunging out of the rain behind us.

I barely saw it in time.

Instinct took over. I threw myself sideways, boots skidding across the soaked pavement as the thing sailed past where I’d been standing. My hands came up automatically, fingers snapping into the familiar pattern as I gathered what little mana I had left.

The spell came together rough and fast.

A firebolt roared from my palm and slammed straight into the creature mid-leap.

The impact lit the rain orange for an instant as flame detonated across its chest. The thing hit the ground hard, thrashing as fire crawled across its ruined body, the smell of burning oil and flesh filling the air.

I heard a scream and a torrent of curse words to my right and behind me.

I spun around just in time to see one of the creatures had Cameron pinned to the ground. The thing had tackled him hard enough to knock the wind out of him, its twisted frame hunched over his body as its jaws clamped down into his shoulder.

Cameron's face was twisted with fury and pain as he drove his fist into the side of its head over and over again.

The creature barely seemed to notice.

Then Dallas was there.

He stepped in close and shoved the muzzle of his gun against the side of the thing's skull.

The shot went off with a deafening crack.

The creature's head exploded.

Black sludge and shredded metal sprayed everywhere, splattering Cameron, Dallas, and anyone else unlucky enough to be nearby. The body went limp instantly, collapsing across Cameron with a heavy, dead weight.

"Holy fuck—!" Cameron gasped.

He shoved the corpse off him with both hands, the ruined body rolling away and hitting the pavement with a dull thud.

Milyah was already moving.

She dropped beside him and grabbed his arm, her hands glowing faintly as she started working a healing spell into the wound. Cameron gritted his teeth but didn't protest, his breathing coming in harsh, ragged bursts.

But they didn't get more than a second.

Another creature came charging straight at them through the rain.

Milyah and Cameron scrambled in opposite directions as the thing lunged, claws slashing through the space where they'd been kneeling a moment before.

We're not going to survive.

The thought hit me out of nowhere, sharp and cold, cutting through the chaos like a knife. I coughed hard, the taste of bile burning the back of my throat as I forced it back down.

It wasn't looking good.

Avery had his back to what was left of the van, rifle up, firing short bursts whenever one of those things got too close. The ruined vehicle behind him looked like it had been dropped from a building—roof crushed, glass gone, metal twisted inward where that monster had landed.

Cameron was in worse shape. He was still on his feet somehow, but barely. One arm hung awkwardly at his side while he swung the other at anything that came within reach. Blood soaked through the shoulder of his jacket where the creature had bitten him.

Milyah knelt beside him, hands glowing faintly as she tried desperately to patch him up, her spell sputtering every time another one of those things lunged too close.

Dallas wasn't doing much better.

He stood a few feet away, breathing hard, weapon up, firing whenever something moved. Even from where I stood I could see how tight his movements were getting—fatigue catching up with him, ammo running low.

We were falling apart.

Normally I wasn't much for praying.

But right then I started praying anyway—to any god that might still be listening.

“Hamish!” Milyah's voice cut through the screams and crashing rain like it was the only real thing left in the world. “Catch!”

Something flew toward me through the storm.

My body reacted before my mind did. I reached out blindly and caught it against my chest. The impact stung my palm.

For a heartbeat, the world narrowed to the object in my hand.

A necklace.

Her necklace.

The small stone pendant lay against my skin, rainwater dripping from its edges. I'd seen it every day since I met her—hanging against her throat, glinting whenever she laughed, something so familiar I'd stopped truly noticing it.

But now it was in my hand instead of around her neck.

And it was warm.

Too warm.

The instant my fingers closed around it, the magic inside awakened.

Mana pulsed through the pendant like a living heartbeat.

Slow.

Heavy.

My breath caught. Every instinct in my body screamed at once.

No.

No, no, no...

The spell building inside it wasn't dormant anymore. I could feel the enchantment unraveling itself, layers of compressed power tightening faster and faster, spiraling toward release.

"Milyah—wait—"

Too late.

The necklace exploded with mana.

Power tore through my arm hard enough to make me gasp. White light swallowed my vision as reality twisted around me. The street bent sideways. Rain froze in the air like shattered glass. The monsters blurred into warped shadows. The entire world stretched apart as if some invisible hand had seized it and ripped it open.

And in that collapsing instant, I looked back.

Milyah stood in the middle of the storm, soaked to the bone, her trembling hands still glowing faintly from the spell she'd stopped casting to save me instead.

To send me away.

Fear was written all over her face.

But she still did it.

Because she'd already decided.

The realization hit harder than the magic.

She wasn't coming with me.

Her eyes locked onto mine one last time, filled with terror, apology, and something painfully close to acceptance.

Then she tried to smile.

And that broke me more than anything else.

"Milyah—!"

The teleport spell activated.

The world shattered into light, and her face was the last thing I saw before she disappeared.

Vesper

Fahrren guided me past the other operating rooms. The hallway was narrow and harshly lit, the overhead strips buzzing faintly as we walked. Most of the doors were closed, thick reinforced panels with small observation windows set into them. Through a few of those windows I caught flashes of chrome limbs, surgical lights, and the silhouettes of machines hanging over operating tables.

From behind some of the doors came the familiar sounds of the Ghoul's work—muffled shouting, the whine of cutting tools, the steady electronic beeping of monitors tracking someone's vitals. Somewhere down the hall a voice broke into a full scream before cutting off abruptly.

I forced my face to stay neutral as we walked. I knew exactly what he was doing. Fahrren loved to parade people past the worst of it, just to see if they'd flinch.

I didn't give him the satisfaction.

He finally stopped at a door near the end of the hall and pushed it open with one hand. The hinges groaned slightly as it swung inward. He stepped aside and gestured me forward with a small flick of his fingers.

"Sit."

The room looked like every other operating space in the shop—stainless steel counters, trays of tools laid out with careful precision, cables hanging from articulated arms mounted to the ceiling. In the center sat the reclining chair.

I lowered myself into it.

It wasn't comfortable by any means. The padding was thin and stiff, and the metal frame underneath shifted slightly with my weight. The restraints mounted along the armrests hadn't been hidden particularly well either.

Fahrren moved over to a nearby console, flicking a few switches and bringing the system to life. Screens blinked awake, casting pale blue light across the room.

"Alright," he said, glancing back at me. "Where's the control port?"

I sighed and tapped the side of my hip and the cover slid open.

"You're not gonna punch me if I try touching you, right?" he asked.

I gave him a flat look.

“Keep it professional and I won’t have any issues.”

One corner of his mouth twitched like he found that funny.

He snorted softly but leaned forward anyway, reaching toward the panel along my hip. A bundle of cables hung from the console beside him, their connectors clinking faintly together as he picked one up. The cold metal of the plug brushed against the control port before he slotted it in with a quiet click.

A moment later, Ghost chimed politely in my ear.

External access detected. Diagnostic interface engaged.

Fahrren straightened slightly, eyes flicking across the monitors as lines of data began to crawl across the screens. Pale blue light reflected off the chrome seams along his jaw while he worked.

“Okay, let’s take a look at this baby,” he said, already absorbed in the readouts. “I don’t often get proper hybrid armors through here. Usually it’s just black-market bastardizations people cobble together and pray don’t fry their nervous system.”

He tapped a few commands into the console, clearly enjoying himself now that he had something interesting to dig into.

I wasn’t sure how I felt about being the interesting one.

Huh,” he murmured after a few minutes.

The room had gone quiet except for the faint hum of the equipment and the soft tapping of Fahrren fingers across the console. Lines of text scrolled steadily down the monitors in front of him, reflected in pale blue light across his face.

“You’ve got a lot of redacted readouts here.”

He leaned closer to the screen, squinting slightly as another window opened. Rows of diagnostic data filled the display—system logs, performance metrics, neural interface reports—but large portions of it were blacked out, replaced with long bars of encrypted placeholders.

“Your AI to blame for that?”

I narrowed my eyes at the back of his head.

“Redacted readouts?”

“Yeah,” he said, scrolling again, clearly intrigued now. “See this?”

He tapped the screen with one finger. More lines of data flickered into place.

“Normally I only see this kind of thing on military types who’ve turned merc. Stuff that used to belong to someone who didn’t want the details getting out.”

He opened another panel. Same thing. Black bars. Locked partitions. Encrypted sections that refused to expand no matter what he tried.

“Normally, I can get around it, but not this one for some reason.”

For a moment he was quiet, studying it.

I had forgotten how—nice—he could be when he was working.

Not nice like a good person. That had never been part of who Fahrren was.

But when he got absorbed in a piece of tech, the mockery faded out of his voice. The arrogance softened into something almost... thoughtful. Curious.

Like a kid taking apart a machine just to see how it worked.

Watching him now, leaning over the console with that same focused expression, it was easy to forget the kind of man he actually was.

Easy to forget the things he’d done.

It didn’t excuse any of it.

And it sure as hell didn’t mean I trusted him.

But when it came to tech like this...

He was good.

Annoyingly good.

“So if it’s redacted, what does that mean for me?” I asked.

Fahrren leaned back slightly from the console, rolling his shoulders slightly. The monitors in front of him continued to scroll with lines of diagnostics, black bars of encrypted data breaking up the readouts like censor marks across a classified file.

“Well,” he said, drumming his fingers lightly against the edge of the console, “two things.”

He turned halfway toward me, one hand gesturing vaguely at the screens behind him.

“Either I set you on your happy way and you keep dealing with the combat AI exactly the way it is now...” he said, shrugging one shoulder, “or I start poking around in all that redacted junk and see if I can get past it.”

He glanced back at the monitors as another warning message flashed briefly across one of the displays before disappearing again into scrolling system logs.

“I arched an eyebrow. “Is that even a question?”

Fahren barked a short laugh under his breath and pushed himself fully upright.

“Knowing your stubborn ass,” he said, shaking his head slightly, “I suppose not.”

I flexed my fingers against the armrests of the chair, the metal joints of my armor giving a faint mechanical whisper as they moved. Across the room, Fahren had already sunk into his console, the glow of the monitors washing his face in pale blue light while he clicked through layer after layer of system menus.

“Someone obviously doesn’t want the specs and such of your armor getting out,” he muttered.

His voice had taken on that distracted tone again, the one he slipped into whenever he got his hands on something interesting. His fingers moved faster across the controls, opening diagnostic panels, scrolling through logs, pulling up partitions of data that flickered across the screens in long columns of code.

I leaned forward slightly, craning my neck to see past his shoulder.

The displays were a mess of information—system diagnostics, neural interface data, combat routines—but every few lines the feed broke apart into thick black bars where the system simply refused to show him anything.

“Let’s see...” he murmured under his breath, eyes narrowing slightly as he scanned the text. “Where’s the registration info...”

Another window popped open.

Then another.

He leaned closer to the screens, the chair creaking softly beneath him.

The room slowly filled with the quiet rhythm of his work: keys clicking, menus opening, the soft hum of processors chewing through encrypted data.

Every so often it'd be punctuated by a "Huh." followed by a few more keystrokes and a "...interesting."

More scrolling text.

Whatever he was digging through had clearly grabbed his full attention now.

He'd been poking around for what felt like forever when suddenly he went very still.

Then he swore under his breath.

The chair scraped violently against the floor as he spun around.

Before I could even ask what he'd found, he was already reaching for the cables running from the console into the control port on my armor.

The connectors snapped free one after another with quick metallic clicks.

"Hey—"

He grabbed my arm and hauled me upright before I'd even fully processed what was happening.

"What's going on?" I demanded, trying to twist free.

"You need to leave."

"What? Why?"

He didn't answer.

Instead he shoved me toward the door with a firm hand between my shoulder blades, his expression tight in a way I'd never seen before.

Seeing him like this made the hairs on the back of my neck stand up.

Something in my armor's logs had rattled him.

I planted my boots against the floor and jerked myself out of his grip.

"Answer me."

"You have some nerve being here," he growled, the words low and sharp like they'd been dragged out of him. "Get out. And don't come back. I don't need you bringing trouble to my door."

For a second I just stared at him.

The shift was so sudden it left me off balance. A minute ago he'd been hunched over the console, muttering to himself while he dug through my armor's diagnostics like a kid taking apart a new toy.

Now his jaw was tight, shoulders rigid, eyes flicking toward the monitors behind him like they might suddenly explode.

"What are you talking about?" I demanded.

He didn't answer.

Instead he grabbed my arm. His grip clamped down around the plating at my forearm and he started hauling me toward the hallway before I could even react.

"I said get out." he snapped.

I dug my heels in for half a step, but he kept pushing, steering me through the doorway and into the narrow corridor. The harsh overhead lights flickered as we passed beneath them, the sound of distant machinery and muffled voices leaking out from behind the sealed operating rooms.

"What the hell is your problem?" I shot back.

Still no answer.

We reached the front of the shop in a matter of seconds. Fahrren shoved past me long enough to slap his hand against the control console mounted beside the entrance.

The heavy door locks disengaged with a series of loud metallic clunks.

The reinforced door slid open with a grinding mechanical whine, letting a rush of cooler outside air spill into the shop.

Before I could say another word, he shoved me through the opening.

I stumbled, caught my balance and turned back. But the door slammed shut hard enough to rattle the frame.

For a moment I just stood there, staring at the sealed metal entrance.

"The fuck, Fahrren?" I yelled at the door.

But there was no response.

Fuck.

Hamish

I rejoined the world with a violent rush of color and motion, the teleport spell dumping me back into reality with an invisible shove that sent me stumbling forward.

My legs gave out almost immediately.

I hit the ground hard, catching myself on my hands as the world spun violently around me. My stomach lurched as the last remnants of the spell bled out of my system. Teleportation always felt wrong, normally it was just disorienting. Right now it felt like being tossed out of a moving vehicle.

I stayed there on my hands and knees for a moment, breathing hard, trying to force the dizziness to settle. My head throbbed and my limbs felt like wet cement, the aftereffects of burning through nearly all my mana hitting me all at once.

Eventually the spinning slowed enough that I could risk standing.

I pushed myself up unsteadily, wiping rain and dirt from my palms as I looked around.

The sight that greeted me made my stomach sink.

I was just outside the city we had set out from earlier that day. The outer structures and broken roadways were unmistakable even in the dim light. The sky above was fading into evening now, the last of the sun slipping below the horizon and casting long shadows across the empty ground.

The storm that had been hammering the town behind us hadn't followed me here. The air was still. Quiet.

Just the wind brushing through dead grass and the distant hum of the city far behind me.

My chest tightened.

I turned slowly in a full circle, scanning the empty road, the nearby buildings, the broken fence line along the edge of the city, hoping against what my heart knew, for any signs of my team.

There wasn't any.

My eyes kept drifting back down the road I'd come from, like if I stared hard enough someone might appear—Avery jogging up with that annoyed look he got when plans went sideways, Dallas swearing about the whole mess, Cameron clutching his shoulder while Milyah fussed over him.

The road stayed empty.

I took a few slow steps forward before I even realized I was moving. My boots crunched on loose gravel,

the sound far too loud in the quiet evening.

If I walked back...

The thought came uninvited.

If I went back now maybe...

I stopped.

My legs didn't move.

Back there the rain had been hammering the ground, gunfire cracking through the streets, those things screaming as they closed in.

The necklace hung from my hand, the chain looped around my fingers. My grip tightened without thinking.

Avery's voice echoed in my head—No one gets to play hero today.

Jason hadn't listened.

And now—

My fingers curled tighter around the pendant until the stone dug painfully into my palm.

I dragged in a breath that didn't want to come and forced myself to look back down the empty road one more time.

Then the dam broke.

"Fuck!" The word tore out of me. Loud in the silence.

My knees gave out again and I dropped hard onto the gravel, the impact barely registering through the sudden rush of heat behind my eyes. My hands braced against the ground, fingers digging into the dirt like I was trying to hold myself together by sheer force.

They weren't coming back.

The thought didn't arrive all at once. It crept in piece by piece, settling heavy in my chest until there wasn't any room left to pretend otherwise.

Avery should've been here already.

He would've been the first one through, shoving the rest of us ahead of him, barking orders the whole time like the stubborn bastard he was. Dallas would've been right behind him, still swearing, probably yelling about how much he hated this job. Cameron would've limped through with that crooked grin of his, acting like getting half eaten was just another bad day.

And Milyah—

My throat tightened.

I squeezed my eyes shut, but that only made it worse. The last thing I'd seen was her face in the rain. Pale. Determined. Watching the spell take hold.

Watching me disappear.

I didn't know how long I stayed like that.

At some point the world crept back in around me.

The air had cooled, the heat of the day bleeding away into the evening. The sky above the city had shifted from dull orange to a deep violet, the last light of the sun fading behind the jagged silhouette of towers and antenna arrays.

The city lights had come on.

Rows of white security lamps along the outer wall flickered to life one by one, washing the ground in harsh artificial light. Neon advertisements deeper inside the city pulsed faintly against the low clouds, coloring the sky in smeared bands of pink and electric blue.

The sound reached me next.

Engines humming.

Voices carrying faintly through the air.

The mechanical whine of the city gates beginning their nightly close cycle.

I blinked and wiped at my face with the back of my hand, dragging myself back into the present.

A small line had formed along the access road leading to the gate. Late arrivals trying to make it inside before the system locked down for the night. A couple battered cargo vans idled near the checkpoint while a handful of pedestrians filtered through the security scanners.

Normal life.

The kind that kept moving whether people lived or died outside the walls.

I pushed myself slowly to my feet.

Every muscle protested. My legs felt stiff and hollow, like they belonged to someone else. I stood there for a moment, steadying myself while the world finished settling back into place.

My fingers were still wrapped around the necklace.

I hadn't even realized I was holding it that tightly.

I forced my hand to relax and tucked it into my pocket before starting toward the gate.

Step by step I made my way down the road, joining the last trickle of people heading inside for the night. No one paid me any attention. Just another lone merc coming back from the outskirts—muddy boots, tired eyes, and a look that said the day had gone badly.

A drone hovered near the gate entrance, its scanners sweeping over everyone passing through in quiet arcs of blue light.

One of the guards leaned against the security booth, half watching the line while scrolling through something on his wrist display.

When my turn came, I ducked my head and didn't look up but the drone passed over me with a soft electronic chirp and moved on without incident.

The guard barely looked up.

"Keep it moving," he muttered.

I stepped through the gate.

Behind me, massive servo motors groaned as the armored doors began sliding shut for the night.

I didn't bother booking a hotel. Instead, I made my way straight for the airport.

I needed to get out of this city—this country—as soon as possible.

Every street I walked down felt wrong. Too normal. Too alive. Neon signs flickered overhead, casting shifting colors across wet pavement while crowds moved past me without a second glance. People laughed. Street vendors shouted over the hum of traffic. Somewhere nearby a synth band played loud enough to rattle the windows.

The world hadn't stopped.

But it felt like mine had.

I kept seeing flashes of it every time I blinked—the rain, the creatures, the sound of the van collapsing under that thing's weight. Avery shouting. Cameron screaming. Milyah's face right before the spell ripped me away.

My hand drifted to the necklace in my pocket again.

I shoved it deeper into the fabric and kept walking.

The airport towered above the surrounding district like a fortress of glass and steel, its upper levels glowing with corporate logos and flight boards scrolling endlessly across massive holographic displays. Cargo drones buzzed through the night sky like metal insects while long rows of taxis and shuttle pods ferried travelers in and out of the terminal.

The place was packed.

People moving in every direction—business travelers dragging smart luggage, corporate suits talking loudly into their implants, tourists staring up at the towering departure screens.

No one noticed me.

Just another tired runner passing through.

I knew a guy back in New Seattle who'd probably let me crash at his place for a while. He was good like that. Didn't ask too many questions, which was exactly what I needed right now.

I pulled out my comm and booked the first flight out.

Didn't care where the seat was.

Didn't care how much it cost.

I just needed to leave.

And the sooner the better.

Vesper

I looked back at Fahrren's place, still trying to make sense of what had just happened. The heavy metal door was shut tight now, the shop silent behind it like nothing had happened at all.

None of it made sense.

Fahrren didn't scare easily. I'd seen him stare down armed clients, botched implants, even corporate enforcers without so much as blinking. Whatever he'd seen in my armor had rattled him badly enough to throw me out without another word.

I sighed and shoved my hands into my pockets, forcing myself to look away from the door. Standing around wasn't going to get me any answers.

The street outside the shop was quiet, the usual hum of the district drifting through the night air—distant engines, the buzz of neon signs, voices echoing somewhere farther down the block.

I needed a drink.

I slipped out of the slow-moving crowd of pedestrians and ducked into the recessed doorway of the Rusted Halo. The neon-pink sign above the entrance buzzed faintly, its glow flickering like it was struggling to stay alive. One of the letters—the S—was dimmer than the rest, its color washed out to a sickly rose where the gas inside the tube had started to fade.

I pushed open the door.

The old-fashioned bell hanging above it gave a tired, halfhearted jangle that was immediately swallowed by the wall of electro-synth pulsing inside. Something Korean, probably—sharp beats layered with breathy vocals and too much bass. I'd stopped keeping up with pop culture a long time ago.

The Rusted Halo's interior was dim and hazy, the lighting low enough that most of the room lived in shadow. A thin fog of vapor hung in the air, catching the colored lights that drifted lazily across the ceiling. The place smelled like cheap whiskey, old cigarette smoke, and the faint metallic tang of overheated electronics leaking out of the aging sound system.

A handful of regulars were scattered across the room—some hunched over drinks, others gathered around a flickering holo-table in the corner playing cards. No one paid me much attention when I came in. In this district, minding your own business was practically a survival skill.

Dante was behind the bar tonight, easy to spot even in the gloom.

His blue-black mohawk cut through the shadows like a neon blade, bobbing slightly in time with the beat

as he poured a drink with one hand and wiped down the counter with the other. The movement was smooth—too smooth to be entirely natural.

Most of Dante's augments weren't the flashy kind people liked to show off. No chrome arms or glowing optics.

His were subtler.

Precision work.

Fine motor control upgrades buried under skin and muscle, designed to give him steady hands and impossible coordination—perfect for mixing drinks, shuffling cards, or anything else that required a little extra dexterity.

I slid onto one of the stools, the cracked vinyl squeaking under my weight as it turned slightly on its metal post. The bar top was sticky in places, rings of old condensation marking where glasses had sat too long.

I waited while Dante finished filling another order.

He was halfway through a complicated pour for a pair of dockworkers down the counter, moving with that effortless precision his augments gave him.

Dante slid the finished drink across the counter to its owner, then turned my way.

That grin of his lit up the whole bar.

"Vesper, omae!" he called over the music, scooping up an empty glass and starting to polish it with a worn bar rag. "You're still kicking? Thought for sure some corp goon squad would've slotted you by now."

"They try. Poor bastards keep missing." I gave him a nod back. "Good to see you, Dante. How's the Halo treating you tonight?"

"Not bad." He set the glass down and grabbed another, his mohawk bobbing slightly with the beat of the music. "Haven't had a single fraggin' fight so far."

He pointed at me with the glass.

"Do me a solid and don't start one, yeah?"

"No promises, omae. Trouble likes me too much," I said with a crooked grin.

“I suppose that’s all I can ask for,” Dante sighed.

He leaned an elbow against the bar as he spoke, lowering his voice slightly even though the music would’ve swallowed it anyway.

“Tank’s on bouncer duty tonight. Chummer likes ya, sure—but frag me, he’ll still boot ya if you stir up trouble.”

I rolled my eyes. “So long as nobody picks a fight with me, I won’t.”

Dante snorted and reached for another glass, catching it neatly before it rolled off the drying rack.

“Please,” he said, polishing the rim with the rag slung over his shoulder. “You can be a bit much when you get a few drinks in ya.”

“Speak for yourself, omae,” I shot back, a grin tugging at the corner of my mouth. “I’m perfectly charming. Always.”

Dante shot me a sideways glance, one brow lifting slightly before he barked out a short laugh.

“Charming, sure,” he said. “But predictable after a few drinks? Not a fraggin’ chance.”

I slapped a hand dramatically against my chest like he’d just shot me.

“You wound me, Dante! I can hold my own just fine—frag, I usually hold everyone else’s too.”

A couple of the nearby patrons glanced our way at that, one of them snorting into his drink.

Dante just rolled his eyes and reached for a clean glass from beneath the bar.

“What can I get ya tonight?” he asked. “We’ve got the usual—Neon Shot, Nightcycle Sour, Chrome Whiskey, or a Synth-gin Fix.”

He tilted his head slightly, a sly grin creeping across his face.

“Or,” he added, lowering his voice just a touch, “you want something that’ll actually make you forget the last twelve hours?”

“Tempting,” I muttered, tapping the counter with two fingers while I considered it.

The glass top gave a dull, hollow clack under my knuckles.

“Nah. Just hit me with a Nightcycle Sour, yeah?”

“Sure thing,” Dante said, already turning toward the shelves behind him.

He moved with easy confidence, every motion smooth and practiced. His augments made the whole process look effortless—hands moving faster than they should, bottles caught mid-flip without so much as a wobble.

A bottle of citrus syrup came down first, flipped once over the back of his hand before he snagged it by the neck.

He poured a glowing ribbon of liquid into the shaker, followed by a splash of dark spirits that smelled faintly smoky even from where I sat. Then he added another vial of something faintly shimmering—some bar-grade enhancer that gave the drink its kick.

The colors swirled together inside the metal shaker like neon paint in a gutter after rain.

Dante snapped the lid on and gave it a few sharp shakes, wrists loose, the rhythm almost matching the music pulsing through the bar.

A couple of people at a nearby table watched him work.

Show-off.

But a talented one.

He finished with a flourish, pouring the mixture down the length of a twisted metal stirrer so it spiraled neatly into the glass below. The drink settled into deep violet hues edged with bioluminescent green that glowed faintly in the dim bar light.

Dante slid it across the counter toward me.

I caught the glass easily, the cool condensation biting pleasantly against my fingers.

The first sip hit hard.

Bright citrus.

Deep burn.

And that strange electric aftertaste that always made my tongue tingle.

“Yeah,” I exhaled, letting the warmth settle into my chest. “That’s what I needed tonight.”

“Hey, spare parts, you’re in my seat,” a low voice said behind me, followed by a tap on my shoulder—lazy, casual, the kind of touch someone used when they were used to people moving the moment they

asked.

I turned slowly.

Slow enough to make a point.

Two half-orcs stood behind me, both broad-shouldered enough to block most of the bar's neon glow. Their tusks caught the shifting lights from the ceiling, glinting faintly as they looked down at me. One wore the kind of smug grin that practically begged someone to wipe it off his face.

"Your seat?" I scoffed, leaning back slightly on the stool. "Didn't see any names on it. I'm just enjoying a drink."

The other half-orc shifted his weight.

He was bulkier than the first, thick through the chest and arms, but he carried himself differently—less puffed-up swagger, more quiet awareness. The kind of posture that said he knew exactly how much damage he could do and didn't feel the need to prove it.

He lifted one hand slowly, palm outward.

His knuckles were wrapped in synth-leather, the kind brawlers wore when they didn't want scanner drones tagging their prints after a fight.

"Easy there," he said, voice low and gravel-smooth. "Ain't lookin' to start drek tonight. We've been running our rounds from this spot with our mates for a while."

His eyes flicked over me.

First the armor.

Then the faint glow coming off my drink.

Then back to my face.

Calculating.

Cautious.

Not stupid enough to push the wrong line if he didn't have to.

Unfortunately for him, I was still riding the tail end of the adrenaline spike from earlier, and the Nightcycle Sour had started to settle into my bloodstream with a pleasant little buzz.

So their posturing didn't faze me in the slightest.

I smirked up at them.

"Well, looks like your mates aren't here," I said, lifting my glass a fraction in a lazy toast. "And I happened to find a cozy spot."

A couple of the nearby patrons had started watching now.

Nothing draws attention in a place like the Rusted Halo faster than the smell of a fight brewing.

"Why don't you join her for a drink instead?"

Dante cut in smoothly from behind the bar, sliding a fresh glass onto the counter like he'd been waiting for the exact moment to intervene.

His voice carried that don't-make-me-clean-up-your-blood bartender tone.

The one only regulars ever really picked up on.

I didn't even need to look over to know what he was thinking.

He'd seen my shoulders tense.

Seen the way my fingers had started tapping the counter in that slow rhythm I always fell into when I was deciding whether or not to break someone's nose.

He knew damn well I was about three seconds away from starting trouble if they kept pushing.

"And why would we do that?" the first one demanded.

He leaned in closer, puffing himself up like some street ganger who thought the whole bar was watching him. His breath smelled faintly like cheap synth-beer as his eyes dragged over me.

Armor plates.

Exposed servos.

The faint glow along the seams of my joints.

He looked me over like he was pricing out salvage.

"What's the deal with all the metal parts, hollow frame?" he sneered. "Can't handle a real fight without 'em?"

“I don’t need metal to drop you. Trust me on that.”

A slow smirk tugged at the corner of my mouth.

“And I gotta ask—did you two skip the diplomacy module, or were you just born running low on processor cycles?”

I let the words hang there for a few seconds, watching the gears grind behind their eyes while the music thumped steadily through the Rusted Halo.

Then I added, lightly:

“Come on. Give it your best shot. Maybe you’ll impress me with more than your ability to intimidate bar stools.”

That got a reaction from the first one.

Not a good one.

His grin vanished like someone had flipped a switch. The easy swagger drained out of his posture, replaced by something darker and simmering just beneath the surface. The muscles in his jaw bunched as he stepped in close—too close.

His hand clamped down on my shoulder.

Hard.

The pressure dug into the armor plating with a dull metallic creak.

Mistake.

The bar’s neon lights flickered across his tusks as he leaned in, breath hot with cheap alcohol.

“You got a smart mouth for a hollow frame,” he growled. “Let’s see how it holds up once I—”

He didn’t finish.

I twisted sharply, dropping my weight and rolling my shoulder forward. His grip slipped just enough for me to wrench free. His balance faltered—half a second of uncertainty as his center of gravity shifted.

More than enough.

My elbow drove up and back into the soft gap beneath his ribs.

The impact landed with a solid thud. Air blasted out of his lungs in a harsh grunt and the glasses on the bar rattled from the sudden jolt of movement.

His friend surged forward immediately.

The diplomatic one.

Shame.

I'd almost thought he might be reasonable.

Around us, patrons shifted in their seats, chairs scraping slightly as people leaned back to give the fight space. No one rushed to intervene. In a place like the Rusted Halo, fights were just another form of entertainment.

The music thumped on, bass rattling the glassware.

Even Dante only muttered under his breath.

"Frag me..."

The first half-orc snarled and came at me again, swinging a heavy fist that could've taken my head clean off if it landed.

I ducked under it.

The air from the punch skimmed over the top of my hair as his momentum carried him forward. I pivoted and drove a sharp strike into the side of his knee joint.

Bone met reinforced plating with a dull crack.

He staggered, buckling for a moment, but sheer brute strength kept him upright.

His buddy didn't give me time to breathe.

The bigger one grabbed a nearby bar stool and ripped it off the floor in a single motion, swinging it toward my ribs in a wide, brutal arc.

I snapped backward just in time.

The stool's metal legs scraped across my armor with a loud clang that rang through the bar and drew a chorus of shouts from the onlookers.

Someone whooped.

Someone else started taking bets.

Well damn.

Looked like I'd need to stay on my toes.

The stool came around again—faster this time, whistling through the air toward my side.

I vaulted up onto the bar to avoid it.

Boots thudded against the countertop as I landed in a crouch between half-finished drinks and scattered coasters.

The first half-orc lunged for my ankle.

I kicked out without hesitation.

My heel caught him square across the jaw.

His head snapped sideways and he stumbled back into a passing waitress, sending her drink tray tilting wildly.

Bottles crashed.

Someone cheered louder this time.

Great.

Now it was entertainment.

I pushed off the counter and vaulted back down, twisting midair as neon light streaked across the room. My boots hit the floor behind them with a solid thud.

Both half-orcs spun around, clearly surprised I'd slipped out of their line of attack so easily.

The bigger one tried to pivot toward me, but his bulk worked against him. His boots scraped across the sticky floor as he struggled to turn fast enough.

Too slow.

I straightened, rolling my shoulders once as a feral grin spread across my face.

The pair watched me more carefully now.

The earlier confidence had faded, replaced with wary tension. Their stances shifted instinctively—feet spreading, weight settling forward, eyes flicking between me and each other as if trying to coordinate without speaking.

Out of the corner of my eye, I caught someone new stepping into the bar.

A guy in a worn coat.

He'd stopped just inside the doorway, brow furrowed, confusion written plainly across his face like he'd just walked into the wrong trid scene.

I didn't have time to figure out whether he was about to become my problem.

Because the two half-orcs chose that exact moment to charge.

Really?

Did all brutes follow the same fragging fight script?

I stepped forward to meet them, shifting my weight and tightening my fists.

Ghost was already sliding into place in the back of my mind.

Locking in.

I didn't even get the chance to start a counterattack.

Something hot and crackling slammed into my side.

Lightning exploded through my ribs, white-hot and violent, the shock tearing a grunt from my throat as my muscles seized.

Hamish

The flight to New Seattle was uneventful.

I slept through most of it, slumped in the narrow seat while the aircraft droned steadily across the night sky. Exhaustion finally caught up with me somewhere after takeoff. Between the crash and the steady hum of the engines, my body shut down whether I wanted it to or not.

The sleep helped.

By the time we landed, the worst of the mana burn had faded. My reserves still felt thin, like a muscle pushed past its limit, but at least they were starting to recover naturally.

The airport lights of New Seattle glowed through the smog as we descended, a sea of neon and holo-ads stretching in every direction beyond the landing field.

Once we touched down, I grabbed my bag and caught a taxi outside the terminal.

The ride across the city was a blur of rain-streaked windows and flickering streetlights. Traffic crawled through stacked lanes of autonomous vehicles while massive holo-billboards towered overhead, selling everything from cybernetic implants to corporate insurance plans.

I barely noticed any of it.

My mind kept circling the same memories like a broken loop.

Rain. Gunfire. Milyah's face.

Eventually the taxi dropped me off in a neighborhood I knew well enough. It wasn't the worst part of New Seattle, but it wasn't somewhere you walked around flashing money either.

At the end of the block stood the bar my friend owned.

Music bled out through the walls, heavy bass vibrating faintly through the pavement beneath my boots. Neon lights flickered above the entrance.

I stood outside the door for a minute.

Every time it opened, a burst of laughter and drunken shouting spilled out along with the music. A few patrons staggered outside at one point, leaning on each other as they tried to light cigarettes before wandering off down the street.

For a moment I almost talked myself into leaving.

Maybe crashing here wasn't such a great idea after all.

Then something inside the bar shattered.

Glass broke with a sharp crack, followed by the unmistakable sound of wood splintering and someone shouting in anger.

I hesitated, but pushed open the door and stepped inside.

The music hit me first—heavy bass that rattled the floorboards and vibrated through my chest. Colored lights drifted lazily through a haze of vapor and cigarette smoke, turning the whole room into a blur of neon shadows.

My gaze went immediately to the center of the bar.

A young woman was in the middle of a full-on brawl with two orcs.

One of them was clutching his ribs while the other swung wildly at her head. She ducked the punch and drove an elbow into his throat with a brutal crack that made half the room wince.

To my surprise—

She looked like she was winning.

But what really caught my attention was everyone else.

No one was stepping in.

The crowd had simply backed away enough to give the fight space. A few patrons were leaning on tables watching with amused expressions. Someone had even started taking bets.

Great.

I had come here hoping to talk to my friend, not watch a bar fight turn into a bloodbath.

And if this kept going, that conversation wasn't happening tonight.

I sighed and raised one hand, gathering the faint trickle of mana I'd managed to recover during the flight.

The energy came slowly at first, responding sluggishly after the beating my reserves had taken earlier. Still, it was enough for something simple.

A quick mana bolt.

I shaped the spell out of habit, fingers tracing the pattern in the air as I designated the targets.

Three of them.

The woman.

And the two orcs.

The spell snapped together with a soft crackle of energy.

I released it.

I spotted the woman's cybernetics too late.

Oops.

The spell had already left my hand, the mana bolt cracking across the room in three streaks of pale blue light.

The orcs staggered as the energy hit them—but the moment the electricity flared, the woman jerked violently as well.

Sparks crawled across the seams of her armor. Sparks crawled across the seams of her armor.

A tall troll had stepped up behind the orcs, clearly about to intervene, but the electrical discharge raced through the wet floor, licking through metal and exposed augments before grounding out.

The woman went down hard.

She hit the floor with a heavy thud, limbs locking for a moment as her systems spasmed under the sudden surge.

Right.

That might've been a little stronger than intended.

For a second the entire bar went quiet, the music still pounding but everyone staring at the sudden flash of arcane lightning that had just cut the fight short.

My friend vaulted the bar with surprising speed for someone who spent most of his nights mixing drinks. Glasses rattled as his boots hit the floor and he pushed through the stunned onlookers toward the fallen woman.

He crouched beside her, grabbing her shoulder and hauling her up before the two orcs could recover

enough to start swinging again.

She swayed as he pulled her to her feet, clearly still shaking from the shock running through her implants.

Dante looked around the bar, his eyes scanning the room.

“Alright,” he said sharply, his voice cutting through the music. “You better have a damn good reason for electrocuting one of my best...”

His gaze landed on me.

And then he stopped.

For a second he just stared.

Recognition flickered across his face and the irritation drained away, replaced by something closer to disbelief.

He let go of the woman and stepped toward me instead.

She nearly toppled again when he released her, catching herself against a nearby table with one hand. The metal legs screeched across the floor as she steadied herself.

Dante didn’t even look back.

Instead he grabbed my arm and leaned closer, lowering his voice.

“Hamish,” he said in harsh whisper. “This is the last fragging place you should be right now.”

“Hello to you too, Dante,” I said.

Vesper

I steadied myself against the table as my HUD flickered, died, rebooted, then died again.

The display sputtered across my vision in broken fragments—target brackets flashing on and off, system warnings blinking red before vanishing into static.

“F... fuck,” I swore—or tried to. My tongue felt glued to the roof of my mouth, every muscle in my jaw moving half a second slower than it should. Everything tasted like copper and ozone, the lingering bite of mana still crackling somewhere along my nerves.

“Sorry,” a voice said from somewhere just outside the blur. “Didn’t mean to hit you that hard.”

I blinked hard, trying to force the room back into focus. The Rusted Halo swam around me in smeared streaks of neon and shadow. Someone nearby was still shouting. Glass crunched under someone’s boots. The music hadn’t even stopped.

“What,” I managed, barely. “You just walk into bars and zap the first person you see?”

The guy in the worn coat stood a few feet away now, hands loosely at his sides like he wasn’t the least bit worried about the situation he’d just created.

He had the decency to look mildly embarrassed.

Mildly.

But the shrug that followed wiped that right out.

“Well, you were causing quite the scene,” he said far too breezily for someone who’d just more or less electrocuted a stranger. “So it’s kinda your fault.”

“My fault?” I spat.

Or tried to. The words came out slurred and rough, like my tongue had forgotten its job somewhere between the lightning strike and now.

“Oh, that’s rich,” I forced out. “I’m gonna make you regret that.”

The guy lifted his hands in a half-hearted defensive gesture that looked more bored than cautious.

“I’d stay down,” he said calmly. “Or at least not try picking a fight with me. I’m not above putting another bolt in you.”

I glared up at him, forcing my fingers to curl against the edge of the table while my armor's servos whined softly in protest.

"If you hadn't fried my systems," I growled, "I'd make you eat those words."

Dante finally let go of the mage's arm and stepped back toward me, shaking out his hand like he'd just finished holding back a particularly stubborn dog.

"Hamish is good people," he said, jerking a thumb over his shoulder toward the mage. "If a little... spell-happy."

"Spell-happy?" the mage—Hamish—echoed, making a face like he'd just been personally insulted. "That makes it sound like it's my fault."

"That's because it is," I muttered, still braced against the table while my HUD tried—and failed—to stabilize.

The display flickered uselessly across my vision before dropping out again.

"Shut up for a damn second, Vesper," Dante snapped before Hamish could fire back.

He stepped in beside me and slid an arm under mine, hauling me upright with a grunt as the room tilted unpleasantly for a moment. "C'mon."

He guided me back toward the bar while the scattered crowd slowly drifted back to their drinks and conversations like the fight had been nothing more than an intermission.

"Frag, omae," Dante muttered under his breath, adjusting his grip on my arm. "You're heavier than you look."

"If he caused any permanent damage to me or my armor," I growled through clenched teeth as we reached the counter, "he's paying for the repairs."

Behind us, Hamish scoffed.

"If I'd wanted to actually damage you," he said casually, "you wouldn't be talking right now."

"Not helping," Dante shot back immediately, stabbing a finger in his direction. "Save the ego for someone who isn't still buzzing from whatever you threw."

Hamish raised both hands in a placating gesture. Faint threads of mana still shimmered around his fingers, crackling softly like static in the air.

“Look, I throttled it down,” he said. “Mostly. You started a bar brawl—what was I supposed to do?”

“Not fry me,” I retorted.

“Could’ve fooled me,” he muttered.

Dante let out a long, exhausted sigh—the kind only bartenders and long-suffering friends ever perfected.

Then, with a grunt, he eased me down onto one of the stools.

“Stay,” Dante ordered, pointing at the stool like I was some kind of unruly dog.

Then he circled back behind the bar.

Glasses clinked as he grabbed one from the rack and filled it from the tap. The water splashed into the tall cup, clear and scentless—no alcohol, no additives, just the boring stuff my body probably needed.

He set it down in front of me with a dull thunk and fixed me with the full force of his bartender glare.

“Hydrate,” he said. “Or I’m cutting you off from everything stronger tonight.”

The glass sweated slightly in the dim light, cool condensation already beading along the outside.

“You should probably cut her off anyway,” Hamish muttered from a few steps away, jerking his chin toward me. “Before she starts something else.”

“Alright, that’s enough needling, mage,” Dante snapped, snapping a bar towel through the air in Hamish’s direction like it might double as a weapon.

“What actually brings you in?” he continued. “Y’know—other than lighting up my regulars like you’re headlining a fragging magic show?”

Hamish scowled at that, the expression wrinkling the bridge of his nose. “Hey,” he said defensively. “In my defense, bar brawls get messy fast.”

He blew out a breath and dragged a hand through his messy reddish hair, leaving it sticking up at odd angles like he’d run his fingers through it one too many times tonight.

For a moment he glanced around the bar.

A few patrons were pretending not to listen. Others weren’t pretending at all. The Rusted Halo wasn’t exactly known for respecting other people’s privacy.

“Look,” Hamish said, lowering his voice slightly. “Can we talk in the back?”

He jerked his head toward the hallway behind the bar.

“Feels like half the city’s listening,” he added. “And I don’t want this conversation getting legs.”

Dante arched an eyebrow at that, the bar towel paused halfway through wiping down the counter as he studied Hamish like he was trying to decide whether the mage was joking.

My gaze flicked over the mage’s disheveled appearance.

He looked like he’d been through hell.

Up close it was even worse than I’d first thought. His coat was wrinkled and dust-streaked, one sleeve faintly scorched along the cuff. Strands of his reddish hair stuck out in every direction like he’d run his hands through it a dozen times on the way here. There was a faint sheen of sweat on his brow, and the circles under his eyes made it look like sleep had been optional for the last few days.

“Alright,” Dante said. “Back room. Because if you knew what I know, you wouldn’t be standing out here in the open.”

I pushed myself off the stool, the vinyl squeaking faintly under me as I slid to my feet. My ribs still buzzed faintly from the mana hit, and my HUD flickered once across my vision before going dark again.

Yeah. Still not happy about that.

No way in hell I was letting them disappear into the back without me.

“Is she coming with us?” Hamish asked.

He didn’t even try to hide the doubt in his voice. His gaze slid over me—taking in the armor, the lingering stiffness in my posture, the way I braced a hand against the bar for balance. The look said everything he didn’t bother putting into words.

Liability.

Dante caught it too.

He shot the mage a brief look before nodding toward me.

“Vesper’s many things,” he said, grabbing the towel and tossing it over his shoulder as he stepped away from the bar, “but she’s not one to spill secrets.”

I snorted quietly at that, pushing myself upright and following after them.

“Especially if she’s paid,” Dante added dryly as he started guiding us toward the hallway that led to the

back rooms.

Vesper

The mage reluctantly pulled out the chair across from me and lowered himself into it, like sitting still was the last thing he wanted to be doing. Dante took the third chair and leaned back slightly, arms folded across his chest as he studied Hamish.

The back room was quieter than the bar. The music out front thumped faintly through the wall, dull and distant, while the hum of refrigeration units filled the rest of the silence. Somewhere nearby a compressor clicked on, vibrating faintly through the floor.

Hamish rubbed a hand over the back of his neck and glanced between the two of us.

“So,” he said at last, voice low. “What do you know? Why is this the last place I want to be right now?”

Dante tilted his head slightly. “You really haven’t heard?” he asked.

“Heard what?” Hamish demanded irritation creeping into his voice. “I’ve been out of the country.”

Dante leaned back a little farther in his chair, letting out a slow breath through his nose.

“Well,” he said, “first thing you should probably do is start avoiding public altogether.”

Hamish blinked.

“Why?”

Dante’s eyes flicked briefly toward the closed door leading back to the bar, like he was checking it was still shut.

Then he looked back at the mage.

“I’m honestly surprised you even made it back here.”

That got Hamish’s attention.

His posture straightened immediately, tension snapping into his shoulders.

“What the hell are you talking about?” he demanded.

Dante didn’t answer right away.

Instead he glanced sideways at me, like he was silently reminding himself that I was still part of the conversation whether Hamish liked it or not.

“You’ve got a bounty on your head, omae.”

For a second the words just hung there.

My eyebrows shot up before I could stop them. “How much?”

Dante turned his head slowly and fixed me with a look that could’ve stripped paint off the walls. “Not happening.”

I leaned back in my chair, crossing my arms over my chest. “Are you going to try to stop me?” I asked.

Dante didn’t hesitate. “I’ll toss you out on your ass if you try.”

His gaze shifted back to Hamish. “On that note, why are you even here?”

“I was told I could pick up some help from here.”

Dante arched an eyebrow, leaning back just enough to look offended in that theatrical way only he could manage. “That’s a bold assumption. Makes it sound like my lovely establishment is a front for shady business.”

I choked back a laugh—barely. Dante’s “lovely establishment” had seen more backroom deals, illegal drop-offs, and emergency patch-ups than most fixer dens. But sure we’ll go with lovely.

Hamish wasn’t so lucky. He snorted slightly then coughed to cover it up. “I mean—hypothetically,” he said. “If someone were running shady operations out of a bar, I’d assume they’d be... well. Discreet.”

Dante’s grin widened. “You’re doing a terrible job of sounding like you don’t already know the answer.”

Before Hamish could respond, I finally cut in, done with him skirting the actual point.

“If you’re here chasing hypotheticals,” I said dryly, “then I’m sorry to be the bearer of bad news, but you’re out of luck.” I tilted my head, studying him. “Either you wanted a trip out here, or this is one gods-awful vacation plan. Which is it?”

Hamish’s jaw tightened as he glanced back at me, irritation flickering across his face. “I really don’t think that’s any of your business. Then he turned to Dante, like he was trying to pretend I wasn’t even in the room. “You sure she’s with you?”

“Unfortunately.” Dante said without hesitation. “And permanently.”

“Lucky me,” I added sweetly.

“Look,” Hamish said, lifting his hands in a half-defensive gesture, “I came here on behalf of my current

employer. He's looking for one more person—some extra muscle to round out the team he's putting together."

Dante rubbed his chin, studying him with narrowed eyes. "You came all this way because... why?"

Hamish shrugged, like he hadn't just dropped a bomb. "We go way back. Figured I'd cash in that little favor from when I saved your sorry ass in Cyrene."

I arched an eyebrow at that.

Cyrene, otherwise known as the Sleepless City of Sin, was the largest criminal hub in the world. Smugglers, syndicates, assassins, black-market tech dealers... if something illegal existed, odds were good Cyrene had a whole district dedicated to it.

"I've never heard that story," I said tossing him a curious look. "Never knew you spent any time in Cyrene."

"That's because I don't like talking about it," Dante muttered.

His glare slid sideways toward Hamish like he was considering whether tossing the mage out the back door would solve the problem.

"You should have him tell you," Hamish said, failing to fully suppress the grin tugging at the corner of his mouth. He leaned back slightly in his chair, clearly enjoying himself now that the spotlight wasn't on his bounty anymore. "We had a lot of fun."

Dante's expression darkened immediately.

I was fairly sure if looks could kill, the mage would've been a smoking crater in the floor by now.

"So why exactly do you need help from here?" Dante asked. "Don't you have a regular team you work with?"

Hamish didn't answer right away.

He looked down at the table instead, one hand still resting near the edge like he'd forgotten it was there. His fingers slowly curled against the metal surface, knuckles whitening for a second before he forced them to relax.

"Hamish?" Dante said, quieter this time.

Hamish swallowed. His jaw worked like he was trying to get the words to come out in the right order.

“They...” his voice cracked a bit. He dashed a hand across his face. “They didn’t make it.”

“What happened? Does it have anything to do with the bounty on your head?” Dante asked.

“I wouldn’t know who would’ve done that,” Hamish said finally, giving a small shrug that didn’t look particularly convincing. “We were just out for reconnaissance.”

I frowned at that. Recon missions didn’t usually end with entire teams disappearing and bounties showing up out of nowhere.

“You had to have done something,” I said, leaning back slightly in my chair. “Enemies?”

Hamish let out a quiet breath that almost sounded like a laugh, though there wasn’t much humor in it. “What mercenary doesn’t?”

Dante sighed and leaned back in his chair. After a second he flicked his wrist, a holo-screen popping up in the air between us with a faint blue glow. Lines of text scrolled across it as the system pulled up the bounty listing.

“Okay,” he said, squinting slightly as he skimmed through it. “Looks like the bounty says they want you dead.”

He paused for a moment, eyes tracking another line of information before continuing.

“But it’s only active here in New Seattle and Caligo so far.” He shifted the holo slightly with two fingers, expanding one section. “I’m assuming that’s the city you launched your recon from?”

Hamish nodded. “Yeah.”

Dante kept reading, the reflected light from the holo-screen flickering across his face.

“I’m gonna assume someone was tracking you,” he said after a moment. “If it followed you from Caligo.”

His gaze flicked back to Hamish. “So that means all we have to do is figure out how they’re tracking you and get you out of the city for a bit.”

Hamish shifted in his chair but didn’t say anything right away.

Dante continued scrolling through the holo for another moment before dismissing it with a small flick of his hand, the projection collapsing back into nothing.

I listened to them talk through possibilities — trackers, tagged gear, compromised comms — the kind of practical troubleshooting mercs fall into when things go sideways.

Ghost softly chimed in my ear.

At the same time, an amber warning flickered along the edge of my HUD.

I closed my eyes, concentrating. The amber warning still flickered along the edge of my HUD, Ghost's quiet chime fading into the background as I muted the visual feed and shifted priority to the audio filters. For a moment all I could hear was the bar itself bleeding through the wall—the heavy synth bass thumping like a second heartbeat, glasses clinking together, someone laughing too loudly, the scrape of chairs dragging across cheap flooring. Normal noise. Chaotic noise.

Then Ghost isolated something else.

Movement.

Not the uneven shuffle of drunks or the lazy pacing of someone waiting for a drink, but steady footfalls crossing the room with purpose. I pushed the filter gain higher, letting the music flatten into dull vibration while the sharper sounds surfaced. Boots striking the floor in controlled rhythm. Fabric shifting. The faint mechanical click of something rigid brushing against a belt clip.

Weapons.

I stayed still, head tilted slightly as if I were just listening to Dante and Hamish talking, but Ghost continued feeding me small fragments of information. Multiple heat signatures near the entrance. Not patrons spreading out toward the bar or tables—these ones paused just inside the doorway, scanning. One moved left. Another drifted right. They weren't looking for drinks.

They were searching.

My stomach tightened as the pattern clicked together. Nobody moved like that unless they were trained, and nobody scanned a room that carefully unless they were hunting someone. The bounty Dante had just pulled up flashed through my mind again, and suddenly the timing didn't feel like coincidence anymore.

Through the wall I caught a low voice speaking—too quiet for the words to register clearly, but calm. Controlled. The kind of tone people used when they already expected trouble.

Ghost highlighted three positions across my HUD overlay.

Three hunters.

And Hamish was sitting right here in the back room like a beacon.

My eyes snapped open. "He's got to go."

Hamish

“What?” I asked Vesper, but she had already shoved her chair back with a harsh scrape against the floor and was on her feet, her posture suddenly rigid and alert in a way that made the hairs on the back of my neck stand up.

“Three hostiles approaching.” She said as if that explained everything, her eyes unfocused for a fraction of a second like she was looking at something none of the rest of us could see.

Dante didn’t seem to even question what she said. His expression tightened immediately, the easy bartender demeanor vanishing as quickly as it had appeared earlier.

“Bounty Hunters probably.” She added.

I swore under my breath, a cold knot forming in my stomach.

“Well, looks like this visit is cut short.” Dante said, annoyance flickering in his gaze as he straightened in his chair. “Vesper, get him out of here safely.”

She looked ready to argue, her jaw tightening like she wanted to push back.

“Vesper, please.” Dante said.

I could tell that the last thing she wanted to do was have anything to do with me. The look she shot Dante made that painfully obvious, like this whole situation was somehow my fault for walking through the door tonight.

Her gaze hardened slightly, those green eyes darkening like a storm rolling in.

“Fine.” She said through gritted teeth.

“Good.” Dante said. “I’ll hold them off for as long as possible.”

She grabbed my arm and I could hear the servos in her armor spinning up to prepare for a fight, the faint mechanical whine rising from beneath the plates as the system powered up and the metal joints along her arm tightened around my sleeve.

“Let’s go, Mage.”

“I have a contact near the Port. They’ll get you all out of here.” Dante said as he shoved the door open and leaned out just far enough to scan the room beyond.

Judging from a bit of heated argument from up front, it sounded like the bouncer had stopped them for

now. Raised voices bled through the music—someone demanding to be let through, Tank’s deeper voice refusing to budge. People were starting to pay attention to the commotion.

And since Dante’s bar was just a cover for other hunters, it wouldn’t last long, especially if any Dante kept employed caught wind of the bounty. In a place like this, word traveled faster than a bullet, and once someone realized there was real money attached to my head, loyalty would only hold for so long.

Vesper more or less dragged me to the back door, her grip tight on my sleeve as she hauled me down the narrow hallway that smelled faintly of spilled alcohol and old grease from the kitchen. She didn’t slow down, didn’t even look back, just shoved the heavy door open with her shoulder and pushed me out into the alley beyond.

Cold night air hit my face just as my boots cleared the threshold.

But before the door had even finished swinging shut behind us, one of the hunters—a tall, skinny guy who looked more cyborg than human—turned his head our way. The faint glow of optics replaced where his eyes should have been, and the moment they locked onto us his mouth twisted into something sharp and triumphant.

“There he is!”

Vesper swore under her breath. “Run!”

We bolted.

The alley opened out into the back street like a chute dumping us straight into the city’s chaos. Neon signs washed the pavement in sickly pinks and blues, rainwater from earlier still clinging to the cracked asphalt and reflecting the lights in smeared streaks. People crowded the sidewalk ahead—late-night drinkers, workers heading home, a couple arguing loudly beside a street vendor.

I was pretty sure she could outpace me if she really wanted to. Her armor alone probably had more horsepower in it than my legs did. But she stayed a couple paces behind me instead.

She wasn’t letting me out of her sight.

“Did Dante even say who his contact was?” I asked as we dodged civilians at full tilt, nearly clipping a guy carrying a crate of fruit. Someone shouted something angry behind us, but I didn’t slow down long enough to catch it.

“He gave me an address before we left,” she said.

We rounded a corner and the world seemed to tighten for a split second. The street here was narrower, darker, lined with stacked crates and humming vending machines that cast uneven light across the

pavement.

Vesper's hand suddenly clamped onto the back of my jacket.

She yanked me hard to the left.

The motion nearly took my feet out from under me, and for half a heartbeat I thought she'd just decided to drag me into an alley for no reason—

Then something blurred past the spot I'd been standing in.

One of the bounty hunters slammed through the space I had just occupied, moving fast enough that the air displaced against my shoulder. Metal limbs snapped forward with mechanical precision, synthetic muscles hissing as they absorbed the impact of the sudden stop.

If she'd been half a second slower, he would have taken me clean off my feet.

"Fuck."

"Speed build," Vesper said as the hunter turned toward us.

I stepped back, narrowly avoiding hitting her.

"Frag me." She swore as her gaze kept switching from the hunter to me, then flicking past my shoulder to whatever might be closing in behind us before snapping back again.

"What kind of Mage are you?" She asked as a small, almost imperceptible shiver ran through her armor, the faint whine of servos adjusting as she shifted her stance. For a moment I thought I heard her mutter "Not now," under her breath, like something had tried to interrupt her focus, but the words were half swallowed by the noise of the street and the pounding of my own pulse.

"I'm offensive oriented with quite a bit of defensive." I replied, forcing the words out between breaths while keeping one eye on the hunter closing the distance between us.

"Good. Shield yourself while I deal with this asshole."

The hunter was already moving again, thin metal limbs flexing as he leaned forward into another sprint, optics locked directly onto me like targeting lasers.

Next thing I knew she's launching herself at the hunter.

I quickly snapped a shield spell into place, pulling the mana up on instinct and forcing it outward in a tight arc around my body just as she more or less collided with the hunter.

The impact sounded like metal slamming into metal. Vesper hit him hard, driving forward with all the momentum from her sprint, armored shoulder crashing into his chest and forcing him half a step back across the pavement.

She quickly ducked his blow, the hunter's metal arm cutting through the air where her head had been a split second earlier. The strike carried enough force that I could hear the servos in his limb whining from the sudden stop as he corrected his balance.

But as she came up from the dodge, I thought I saw her briefly stumble.

It was subtle, just a hitch in her footing, like her body had moved a fraction of a second slower than she had wanted. For a moment the rhythm of her movements broke, the smoothness from before replaced by something rougher.

And this time I definitely saw a shiver run across her armor.

The plates along her shoulders twitched almost imperceptibly as the servos underneath them adjusted too quickly, tiny mechanical corrections firing one after another like her systems were fighting themselves for control.

"Five damn minutes!" She yelled at no one in particular. "Hold off for five damn minutes!"

The hunter tilted his head, confused for a second, the faint glow of his optics narrowing as he watched her movements like he was trying to figure out if she'd glitched. For a moment he didn't advance, just studied her, head cocked slightly to one side like a machine recalculating its next move.

"You goin' krait?" he asked, the word dripping with amused disbelief as he reached down and slid a knife free from a sheath along his thigh. The blade caught the neon light from the street and flashed coldly as he flipped it once in his hand.

I was wondering the same thing.

Watching her now, the way her stance shifted too abruptly, the faint tremor still rippling through the plates of her armor, it was hard not to think something was wrong under the surface. Whatever had made her shout like that clearly wasn't directed at the hunter.

What had Dante been thinking entrusting my safety to this loose cannon?

Vesper

Fraggin' hell.

My vision dragged sideways, red static smearing along the edges of the HUD as I tracked the hunter's movement. The reticle slipped, lost him for the space between breaths, then caught again, snapping tight as if a leash had been pulled tight.

The pain came with it.

Not clean. Not sharp. A live wire buried deep, buzzing up through the base of my skull, turning thought to grit.

My jaw set against it. Breath in, slow and counted. Hold. Let it bleed out the edges.

Not now.

I drew my own blade, the metal sliding free with a quiet rasp that felt steadier than my head did right now. Firearms would've been easier, but Mercenary or not, there were still too many civilians around. One stray round in a place like this and the wrong person ends up dead.

I could feel the heat of Hamish's stare on my back. I didn't have to turn around to know he was watching every move, probably wondering if Dante had just handed him over to someone who was about to completely lose it.

The hunter charged me again. But something about the angle was wrong, the way his shoulders were turned, the slight shift in his footing as he closed the distance.

He wasn't trying to break through me. Not really. He was trying to draw me just far enough out of position that he could slip past.

Still going for Hamish.

And I knew we didn't have long before his buddies showed up. Dante had bought us time, but not much of it. Thank the gods he'd managed to stall two out of the three hunters back in the bar.

The hunter's arm snapped out in a fast, probing strike meant to keep me occupied while he angled his body to slip around my flank.

I danced back from the feint, boots skidding lightly across the pavement as I adjusted my stance, and cut him off before he could break past me. My blade came up in a tight guard while I shifted sideways, planting myself squarely between him and the mage.

“Start running, Mage,” I said without taking my eyes off the hunter. “I’ll hold him off.”

I sensed him hesitating behind me. “Go! Now!”

“I can’t,” he said.

The hunter lunged again. I caught the strike on my blade, metal shrieking as it slid down the edge before I kicked off his chest and shoved him back a step.

“What do you mean you can’t?” I snapped over my shoulder, never taking my eyes off the hunter.

“I..” He stammered.

I sensed him hesitating. I snuck a glance back at him, careful not to take my eyes off the hunter for too long. Just enough to check that he was actually moving.

He wasn’t.

He was standing there staring, shoulders slightly hunched. Not quite at me. His eyes were fixed somewhere past my shoulder, unfocused, like he was looking through the alley instead of at it.

Like he was seeing something else.

Frag.

The hunter’s blade came down and I caught it on mine, the impact jarring up my arm.

I knew that look.

I’d seen it too often in mercs who drifted into the Halo alone. Guys who used to run with crews that never made it back from the last job.

Teams gone.

Friends gone.

The hunter twisted his wrist and I shoved him back a step.

And the one left standing there when they shouldn’t be.

Alone.

I knew it too well. I’d seen it many times in the mirror before.

“Hamish!” I shouted, “Snap out of it! Get out of your head! You’re here not there!”

The words had barely left my mouth when I felt a familiar cold crawl through my implants. My HUD flickered again as my muscles tensed. They shouldn’t have. There was a subtle hitch in my arms, my fingers flexing slightly around the hilt as Ghost decided that I had dragged this fight on for too long.

Fuck.

The hunter’s blade came in fast, angling for my side. I started to shift back, weight already moving to retreat -

Ghost yanked the movement out of me before I’d even fully decided to move, forcing me to duck, the servos in my armor shrieking at the sudden change of position. The blade passed over my head a split second later.

I fought to correct myself, to rise back up, keep myself between Hamish and the Hunter. My legs didn’t listen.

Instead one swept out sharply, far more aggressive than I would have risked on my own. My heel caught the hunter’s ankle and knocked him slightly off balance, the sudden shift in his footing cracking his stance open for a fraction of a second.

An opening.

Ghost took it before I could stop it.

My arm snapped forward. The recently healed bone in my shoulder cracked faintly under the force of the thrust, a sharp flash of pain shooting up my arm as my grip locked around the knife. The blade punched straight through an exposed seam in his armor, sliding between plates where his stomach underneath had been left vulnerable.

I didn’t even get a chance to pull back.

Ghost twisted my wrist, dragging the blade sideways along the gap.

“You little cunt!” He jerked back hard enough that the blade caught between the overlapping plates of his armor. For a moment it stuck there, the metal wedged deep in the seam where Ghost had driven it. Then his backward stumble tore it free of my grip entirely, wrenching it out of my hand as he staggered away with my knife still buried in him.

Ghost already had me moving before I could even think about reaching for it. My body shifted back automatically as it pulled me just outside the range of his counterattack.

I caught a glimpse of Hamish out of the corner of my eye.

He had snapped out of it.

The dazed, faraway look was gone, replaced with something much more focused, but the way he was staring at me hadn't changed much.

And yeah.

He was definitely looking at me like I was some kind of monster again.

For a split second I managed to shove Ghost's influence aside and take back just enough control to act on my own.

"Move."

I more or less dragged him two steps and then threw him behind a dented dumpster at the edge of the alley, the metal container rattling loudly as his shoulder hit it and he stumbled down into cover.

In almost the same breath, Ghost seized control again.

My body dropped sideways in a sharp dodge before I'd even fully registered the danger, servos screaming in protest as the motion forced my armor to pivot faster than my limiters would normally have allowed.

A burst of gunfire tore through the space I'd been standing in.

Bullets hissed past me, cracking against brick and chewing sparks out of the pavement as they ricocheted down the alley.

Shit.

His buddies had caught up.

I felt control slowly bleed back into my limbs, the tight invisible grip Ghost had on my nervous system easing just enough that my movements were mine again. My breathing was ragged, chest heaving as the alley came back into sharp focus around me. Of course Ghost would give it back right when more enemies showed up.

"Duck!" I heard Hamish yell.

I didn't question it. I dropped instantly, knees and hands hitting the pavement as the air above me suddenly crackled. I felt the sizzle of electricity pass overhead, sharp and hot enough that the hairs along the back of my neck prickled.

A split second later a mana bolt streaked past and slammed into the chest of one of the newcomers. The impact lit the alley in a violent flash of blue-white energy as the man jerked backward, armor sparking as the magic arced across it.

That would buy me some time.

“Get out of here!” I yelled again, my voice echoing off the brick walls. “I’ll hold them off!”

I was basically echoing Dante’s plan, but the logic held. If their target was gone, there was at least a chance they’d break off instead of wasting time finishing me.

The first hunter had recovered, mostly, from the damage Ghost had done. He was moving slower now, the slash along the seam of his armor clearly interfering with something underneath, but the rage in his expression made up for it. He stalked forward again, knife still buried somewhere in his plating, eyes locked on me like he intended to settle things personally.

My HUD wouldn’t settle. Red bled into the edges of my vision, three shapes caught in its grip, outlined like something already decided. The numbers kept talking. Angles, timing, survival odds, but they didn’t sound like anything I needed to hear.

I let most of it fall away.

The world narrowed. Footsteps on concrete. Weight shifts. The way one of them leaned just a fraction too far forward.

Better.

My hand slipped to my sidearm, the motion familiar enough to not need watching. Grip found palm, metal cool, steady.

I still didn’t want to shoot. Even though most civilians had cleared the area, the alley fed out into a busy street and the last thing I wanted was a stray round hitting someone who had nothing to do with this mess. Somewhere in the distance sirens had begun to wail, faint but growing louder, and that meant we were running out of time.

Now I had a timer counting down in my head.

The last thing we needed was an encounter with crooked cops. I’d dealt with them before.

I didn’t like them.

And they sure as hell didn’t like me.

“What’s the best odds?” I asked Ghost.

For a moment there was nothing. Just the sound of my own breathing and the faint mechanical whine of my armor adjusting to my stance.

Then the answer came, flat and immediate.

Best odds take out two. Last one finishes. Mage gets killed.

I swore under my breath.

Figures.

I shifted my stance slightly, lining up the handgun as the hunters began to spread out across the mouth of the alley, trying to box me in. One of them was already raising his weapon, the red glint of an optic catching the dim alley light as he started to take aim.

Then a rifle cracked.

The sound was sharp and distant at the same time, echoing off brick and steel like thunder bouncing through a canyon. A split second later the hunter in the back jerked violently as something punched straight through his shoulder plate. The impact spun him halfway around before he slammed into the wall, armor sparking as he slid down it.

For half a heartbeat nobody moved.

Even the other hunters froze, their attention snapping upward toward the rooftops.

A faint metallic clatter echoed somewhere above us—someone shifting position on a fire escape or rooftop railing. Whoever had taken the shot had a clean angle down into the alley.

The wounded hunter let out a strangled curse as he tried to push himself up, blood leaking through the shattered seam of his armor.

The other two hunters immediately spread out, instincts kicking in as they searched for the shooter.

My own HUD kicked back into overdrive, red indicators flashing angrily as it recalculated the entire engagement. New vectors began crawling across the edges of my vision, probability trees branching faster than I could read them.

An unknown third-party sniper had not even been considered in my calculations.

Threat markers shifted as the system tried to triangulate the shot, scanning rooftops, windows, fire

escapes—anything with line of sight into the alley. The algorithm spat out half a dozen possible firing positions and none of them were close enough for me to verify.

Odds were they weren't on my side.

The hunters were thinking the same thing. One of them had already swung his rifle upward, trying to track the rooftop lines while the one I had stabbed dragged their wounded partner toward the wall.

For a moment the alley went strangely quiet.

Even the hunters hesitated.

The one who had been sweeping the rooftops slowly raised his rifle, tracking across the fire escapes and broken balcony rails above us, waiting for the shooter to expose themselves again. The wounded hunter leaned harder into the wall, breathing rough through clenched teeth while blood seeped steadily through the seams of his armor. The one I'd stabbed stayed low, shoulders tight, as he tried to angle himself for a better line of sight.

Then the hunter who had been scanning the rooftops never got the chance to fire.

His head snapped sideways as a round punched clean through his temple, the impact whipping his body half a step off balance. For a fraction of a second he just stood there, expression frozen in surprise, like his brain hadn't yet caught up with what had happened.

The report of the rifle followed a heartbeat later, echoing sharply between the brick walls.

Then his body folded.

His rifle slipped from his hands as he dropped hard beside it, the weapon skidding a short distance before coming to rest near a gutter.

Hamish

Sweat beaded across my brow as I strained to maintain the shields around both of us.

One barrier around a group was difficult enough. Two separate constructs, split between two moving people, was something else entirely.

It felt like trying to hold shut two collapsing doors with bare hands while something on the other side kept pushing harder.

Mana burned hot behind my eyes. My stomach twisted suddenly and violently enough that I nearly lost focus.

Fuck.

Then the sniper rifle cracked.

The sound ripped through the alley.

For half a second I wasn't there anymore.

The shield around me stuttered. Vesper's flickered hard, thinning so suddenly I saw the outline of it collapse before instinct snapped it back into place.

The shot echoed again in my head, wrong and distant at the same time.

Not a city alley.

Rain streaked streets. Those monsters. Twisted. Screaming like demons from hell. Gunfire. Milyah's screams as Jason threw himself at those things.

My breathing hitched.

No.

I squeezed my eyes shut hard enough that it hurt, trying to force the memory back down before it swallowed me whole.

The alley blurred at the edges anyway. For one sick second I couldn't tell which sounds belonged to now and which belonged to then.

Another crack of gunfire somewhere above us.

My pulse spiked so hard my hands went numb.

I almost dropped the shields completely.

"Hamish!" Her scream ripped me from my spiraling thoughts and slammed me back into the alley.

I shook my head chasing away the lingering fragments of memories and glanced towards her. Vesper was crouched slightly not too far from the mercs her body still poised for attack.

One of the mercs was slumped against the wall nearby, his face twisted in pain as blood seeped through the cracked seams of his armor.

"I didn't sign up for this," he hissed through gritted teeth, "we are not getting paid enough for this bullshit."

Of course he hadn't.

Vesper had more or less attempted to gut him like a fish before a sniper round tore through his shoulder. Honestly, I was a little surprised he hadn't bled out already.

The one merc still standing flicked her gaze between the body crumpled on the ground and Vesper before looking up toward the rooftops, searching for the sniper. I could practically see the calculation happening behind her eyes, weighing the odds of staying against the odds of running.

Under her breath she hissed something in a foreign dialect, sharp and fast, then quickly moved to her injured companion and hauled him down the alley with her.

Once they disappeared down the alley, I heaved out a shaky breath and let the shields collapse. The spellwork unraveled instantly, dissolving into faint sparks of mana as I sank to my knees, chest heaving from the effort.

I knew the sniper was still out there somewhere, watching from the rooftops, but I couldn't keep both shields standing any longer. My head was pounding, my hands trembling faintly from the strain.

Vesper steadied herself against the wall for a second, one hand pressed briefly to her side before she pushed off and stalked over to me. Her movements looked controlled at first glance, but I could see the stiffness underneath them now, the slight hitch in her posture from injuries and overstrained implants.

Before I could say anything, she smacked me upside the back of the head.

Pain flared through my already throbbing skull, sharp enough to make me wince as fresh nausea rolled unpleasantly in my stomach.

"I told you to run, you fragging idiot," she snapped.

I rubbed the back of my head weakly while trying to steady my breathing. Up close she looked even worse than before. Her armor was scuffed in places, streaked with blood and grime, and the faint red flicker still ghosting across the edges of her HUD reflected dimly in her eyes whenever she blinked. There was tension wound through every line of her body, like she was still halfway expecting another attack at any second.

“I don’t need you freezing up like that again,” she continued, voice lower now but no less sharp. “You drop those shields at the wrong moment and we both end up dead.”

I flinched slightly at her words.

They stung, but I knew she was right. She was risking her life for a complete stranger because Dante had asked her to, and I had nearly gotten both of us killed because I couldn’t keep my head together when things went bad.

“I—” I started, already trying to force out an apology.

The words never left my mouth.

She suddenly grabbed the front of my jacket and shoved me sharply behind her before stepping forward into a defensive stance. The movement was so abrupt I nearly lost my footing entirely, stumbling back against the wall as she drew her sidearm in one smooth motion.

“I know you’re there,” she called into the alley.

For a second nothing happened.

Then a figure dropped soundlessly from the fire escape above us.

An elf.

He landed lightly despite the height, boots barely making a sound against the pavement as he straightened to his full height. Tall, like most elves, but not like the ones I was used to seeing around the city.

His skin was dark brown, almost bronze beneath the alley lights, and his hair was raven black instead of the pale silver-white most elves wore naturally. His eyes were dark, coffee brown, sharp and alert as they flicked briefly between the two of us.

And slung over one shoulder was a sniper rifle.

The long barrel caught the dim alley light as he shifted, confirming immediately what both of us had already guessed.

He inclined his head slightly in greeting, almost casual despite the weapon.

I was caught completely off guard by the low warning growl that rumbled in Vesper's chest.

Every muscle in her body had gone taut again, shoulders squared as she kept herself planted firmly between me and the elf. The hand holding her sidearm stayed perfectly steady, though I noticed her finger hovering just outside the trigger guard.

"You're the sniper?" she demanded.

"Guilty," the elf replied easily.

His voice was calm, almost amused, but he slowly lifted both hands in a placating gesture, making no move toward the rifle slung over his shoulder.

Then he said, "Black?"

"The word sounded completely out of place, more like the start of a conversation than some kind of challenge, but it was enough to make Vesper lower her weapon slightly.

"Neon," she replied without hesitation.

I looked between the two of them in confusion as she finally reholstered her sidearm, though the tension hadn't fully left her posture.

The elf nodded once.

"Sethinira," he introduced himself and offered a hand. "Dante gave me a heads up call. Figured you'd need backup."

Up close, he looked far less polished than the corporate elves I was used to seeing in the city. His dark coat was worn at the edges, reinforced in places with mismatched armor plating, and faint burn marks scarred one sleeve near the wrist.

Gods, he looked almost as unkempt as I probably did.

Sethinaria stepped closer and extended a hand toward Vesper. After a brief hesitation, she clasped it firmly.

"All things considered," she said, "the help is most welcome."

He nodded once before his gaze shifted toward me. "Any idea why you've got a bounty on your head?"

I shook my head. "No."

Sethinaria made a low, noncommittal sound in the back of his throat.

“It’s a pretty big one,” he said. “Enough to set up most mercs for life.” His expression barely changed as he added, “If I didn’t owe Dante a couple favors, I probably would’ve jumped at the chance.”

If looks could kill, the poisonous glare Vesper leveled at him probably would have dropped him instantaneously.

“Well,” I said quickly, before she could launch herself at him, “I appreciate you not doing that.”

Sethinaria looked entirely unbothered by the glare leveled at him, though one corner of his mouth twitched faintly like he found the whole thing amusing.

Vesper, meanwhile, looked two seconds away from ripping his throat out with her teeth.

The Kenzai stared him down for a long, tense moment before finally looking away with an irritated click of her tongue.

“Let’s find a safer place to talk,” she muttered. “Cops will be all over this area any minute now.” And she turned and walked away.

Vesper

As I stalked down the alley, Sethinaria fell easily into step beside me like he'd been there the whole time.

"I know a shortcut to the docks," he offered. "Less chance of us getting jumped on the way."

I shot him an irritated look but didn't immediately tell him to frag off, which was probably the closest thing to gratitude he was getting from me tonight.

I glanced back to make sure he was still following.

The mage looked exhausted. His face had gone pale beneath the alley lights and there was still that slightly unfocused edge in his eyes that told me he hadn't fully pulled himself back together after freezing up earlier.

I slowed slightly, letting him catch up before subtly shifting position so he walked a little ahead of me instead.

Easier to keep an eye on him that way.

"Fine," I said finally. "But if anything happens, I'm going to assume you're the one who led us into a trap, and you'll be the first one I kill."

Sethinaria didn't so much as flinch. "I wouldn't expect anything else," he replied calmly.

The annoying part was that he sounded completely sincere about it.

He moved ahead slightly after that, leading us toward a narrow side street branching off from the alley while I stayed close enough behind to keep him well within reach if he tried anything stupid.

Not that I thought he would.

Mostly.

I'd been burned too many times. I knew better than to hand out trust that easily. Especially to another merc in the middle of New Seattle.

Behind me, Hamish nearly stumbled over a crack in the pavement before catching himself at the last second. I glanced back automatically, checking that he was still upright.

After ducking through what felt like half the fragging district, weaving between narrow back alleys, maintenance corridors, and rusted service walkways, the skyline finally began to open up around us.

The docks.

Cold salt air cut through the lingering stink of blood, smoke, and alleyway rot as we emerged onto a cracked concrete loading platform overlooking the harbor. Cargo cranes loomed overhead like skeletal giants, their warning lights blinking red through the fog rolling in off the water. Somewhere out across the bay, ship horns groaned low and distant.

For the first time since the hunters jumped us, things felt... quieter.

Not safe.

Never safe.

But quieter.

I glanced back toward Hamish. The mage looked exhausted. His steps had grown slower over the last several blocks and there were dark circles forming beneath his eyes now, the kind that came from magical burnout as much as stress. Every so often his gaze drifted toward sudden noises—a slammed car door, a distant shout, the metallic groan of shifting cargo containers—before he visibly forced himself to refocus.

Yeah. He was barely holding himself together.

Sethinaria finally slowed near the edge of the docks and turned toward us.

“This is where we part ways for now,” he said.

The elf inclined his head slightly, dark hair stirring faintly in the sea wind. “May the stars guide you on your journey.”

Then, before either of us could respond, he turned and disappeared back into the maze of lights, fog, and steel swallowing the city behind us.

I watched him go for a few seconds longer than I probably needed to.

Mostly to make sure he actually left.

Then I turned back toward Hamish.

“Let’s get going,” I said. “Lingering out in the open won’t do us any good.”

I subtly tilted my head toward a pair of dock workers further down the platform who had stopped pretending not to stare at us. Honestly, I couldn’t blame them. Between the blood, damaged armor, and the fact Hamish looked like he was one bad day away from collapsing entirely, we probably looked like

we'd crawled straight out of a firefight.

Which, technically, we had.

Hamish followed my gaze and immediately stiffened slightly when he noticed the workers watching us.

"Agreed," he muttered.

The harbor wind tugged at the edges of his coat as he stepped closer, keeping his head down while we moved away from the open docks and back toward the tangled maze of shipping containers and rusting warehouses lining the waterfront.

A few moments of silence passed between us as we moved through the docks. Somewhere nearby, machinery groaned while waves slapped rhythmically against the support pylons beneath the platforms.

"Do we even know who this contact of Dante's is?" Hamish finally asked.

I gave my head a slight shake.

"No," I admitted. "But knowing Dante, we'll know them when we see them."

Hamish glanced sideways at me, looking deeply unconvinced. "That doesn't exactly inspire confidence."

A tired snort escaped me despite myself. "Trust me, if Dante picked them, they're either going to be incredibly helpful or the biggest pain in the ass you've ever met." I paused briefly before adding dryly, "Possibly both."

The mage looked like he wanted to ask more questions, but his attention kept drifting toward every sudden noise around us. Every slammed container door or distant shout made his shoulders tense ever so slightly before he forced himself to relax again.

"Relax." I said lightly bumping into him,

"That's rich coming from someone as tightly wound as you." He returned.

"You have me there." I said.

A faint smile tugged at the corner of his mouth before he looked away. "So what's your story?" He asked. "Never worked with a Kenzai before."

I shrugged my shoulders slightly. "Not much to share."

He took my hint and let it slide.

We had just turned down a narrow space between a stack of shipping containers when I spotted someone not too far ahead of us. I instantly grabbed Hamish by the shoulder and shoved him behind me.

The figure stopped several feet away and extended their hands palms up. "Are you Vesper?"

"Who's asking?"

"My name is Solace. Dante said you guys would be coming." They took a step forward and it was a tall, black haired Cambion.

I didn't relax in the slightest. "How do I know you're not a Bounty Hunter?"

"If I was, neither you or the mage would have seen me coming." She responded.

I hesitated. She wasn't wrong. Ghost hadn't picked her up at all. And, even now, the AI was having a hard time fully picking up her outline and heat signature. "I'm gonna need a little more than that."

Solace rolled her eyes, "Dante did say you have trust issues." She tossed something at me and I caught it without thinking.

I glanced down at it. The object was a small coin with the Rusted Halo's picture printed on one side and a crossed knife and gun on the other. Only people who worked closely with Dante ever had one of these, unless of course she killed someone to get her hands on it.

"Enough proof?" She asked.

What are the chances she stole this off a different operative? I thought at Ghost.

The AI was silent for a moment then [Approximately thirty five percent chance of that possibility. However, her body language suggests otherwise.]

I nodded slightly then said aloud. "It's enough proof for now. But I warn you, if you're lying I will find out and I will kill you."

Solace grinned. "Wouldn't expect anything less from Dante's favorite pet."

I scowled. "What do you mean by that?"

She laughed. "Nothing, I swear, I've just heard a lot about you. Dante sings your praises all the time."

I scoffed slightly "We must be talking about two different people."

"Can we not be out in the open?" Hamish interjected.

"He's right." Solace said. "We need to get moving."

With that we followed her into the maze that was the docks.

Hamish

Solace led us through the docks, weaving between stacks of cargo containers and rusting cranes that loomed over the waterfront like skeletal giants. The smell of salt, diesel, and rotting seaweed hung heavy in the night air. Eventually she stopped in front of a warehouse that looked no different from the dozens surrounding it—corrugated steel walls, faded identification markings, and enough rust around the edges to suggest nobody had cared about appearances in years.

Vesper immediately tensed. Most people probably wouldn't have noticed it, but I did.

Her shoulders had been tight ever since we'd met Solace, but the closer we got to our destination, the worse it became. Every exchange between them carried an edge. Every question sounded like an interrogation. Even when Vesper wasn't speaking, she watched the Cambion the way someone watches a venomous animal—careful not to look away for too long.

I couldn't really blame her.

Truthfully, I wasn't sure I trusted Solace either.

Part of that was simple self-preservation. Part of it was the fact that she was a Cambion.

She looked the part.

Pale skin that seemed almost luminous beneath the dock lights. Curving horns sweeping back through dark hair. Sharp features that always looked one smile away from trouble. More than once I caught a glimpse of her hands and thought I saw clawed fingertips before they disappeared beneath her sleeves again. Whether that was imagination or reality, I couldn't say.

Either way, she wasn't exactly reassuring.

Solace ignored our suspicion entirely and stepped up to the warehouse door and knocked on it and I thought there seemed to be a pattern to it.

A moment later a small viewing panel slid open. Someone inside peered out. The change was immediate.

Whatever guarded expression the guard had been wearing vanished the instant he recognized her. The panel snapped shut again. Heavy locks disengaged from the other side of the door with a series of metallic clunks.

Then the door swung inward.

The man inside stepped aside and waved us through without a word.

The moment we stepped inside, the door swung shut behind us. Heavy bolts slid into place one after another, each lock engaging with a dull metallic clunk that echoed through the warehouse. I found myself glancing back at the entrance as the last one locked. Rationally, I knew the sound was supposed to be comforting. It meant nobody was getting in without permission. Unfortunately, it also meant nobody was getting out without permission. Given the week we'd been having, I wasn't entirely sure which possibility bothered me more.

The warehouse itself was larger than it had appeared from outside. Stacks of shipping crates occupied most of the floor, arranged in loose rows that created narrow pathways through the building. Cargo nets hung from support beams overhead. Work lights dangled from cables stretched across the ceiling, casting pools of yellow light that never quite reached the corners. The place smelled strongly of saltwater, machine oil, damp wood, and old rope. It reminded me of every dockside storage facility I'd ever visited, which was probably intentional. Places used for smuggling generally benefited from looking exactly like places used for legitimate business.

There were perhaps a dozen people inside.

Most of them were older. Not elderly, but old enough that decades of physical labor had left visible marks. Their faces were weathered by wind and sea air. Their hands looked like they'd spent entire careers hauling cargo, repairing equipment, and solving problems that couldn't be fixed with a software update. A few looked up when we entered. Their eyes lingered on Vesper and me for a moment before returning to whatever they had been doing. Nobody looked alarmed. Nobody seemed particularly interested.

"You two can stay here for now," Solace said, drawing my attention back to the present. She spoke casually, as though she were offering directions rather than arranging an illegal escape. "The next boat we can smuggle you out on won't be here until much later tonight."

Vesper shifted her weight slightly as if she couldn't decide if she wanted to stay or run. Eventually, she gave in. "Okay." She inclined her head slightly. "Thank you for your assistance." The way she said thank you made it seem like it had pained her to say it.

"Asten!" Solace called, "Can you bring some food for our guests?"

A boy scrambled into view carrying a small box. He held it out to me and when I looked inside, there were a few apples.

